
North Lake

Waukesha County, Wisconsin — 440 acres, 78 ft, river-fed and stained

Every sheet in the Lake Country guide, bound in one document: the lake and its depth map, a page for each species, a page for each rig, and the reference sheets. Each page is also published on its own, and the two are the same document — this is those sheets bound, not a rewriting of them.

Revised 2026-07-25. Regulations quoted anywhere in this document are the 2026–27 rules and they change every year. Only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.

What is in here

Part	Sheets
I. The lake	North Lake — overview, depth map with numbered spots, and the season-by-season table of what holds where
II. Species	Largemouth bass, smallmouth bass, walleye, northern pike, muskellunge, bluegill, pumpkinseed, black crappie, yellow perch, rock bass, cisco
III. Rigs	Slip bobber, lindy, Carolina, Texas, wacky, drop shot, jig-and-minnow, three-way, split shot, quick-strike, tip-up
IV. Reference	Reading water, lures and baits, the seasonal calendar, knots, handling and release, a first trip
V. Cooking	A filleting and cooking sheet for each of the eleven species, including the five-fillet method that defeats a pike's Y-bones

How to use it

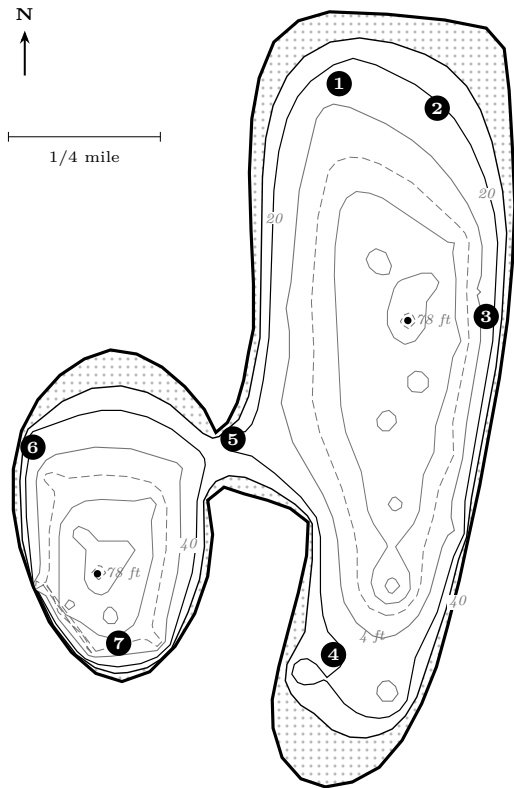
The numbered spots on the depth map are the guide's spine. Every species sheet and most rig sheets refer back to them, so Pine 4" or North 5" always means the same piece of water. Read the lake sheet first; after that the guide is meant to be flipped through rather than read.

I The Lake

The water itself: what it is made of, how deep it goes, where the structure is, and which of the nine (or seven) marked spots is worth your time in which month.

North Lake sits two miles north of Pine Lake and fishes almost nothing like it. It is a river lake: the Oconomowoc River enters the south-west lobe and leaves at the north-east corner, and that flow keeps the water stained where Pine Lake is glass. Lower clarity is an advantage. Fish here hold shallower, feed later into the morning, and are far less leader-shy. The lake is also two lakes — a long main basin and a round south-west lobe, each with its own deep hole near 78 ft, joined by one narrow neck that every fish in the system has to swim through.

Surface	440 acres (449 acres on the 1898 survey); 3.44 miles of shoreline
Depth	78.4 ft maximum. Two separate holes: one in each basin
Clarity	Low. Stained, river-fed water — shorter weed line, shallower fish, more forgiving of heavier line
Hydrology	Oconomowoc River in at the west end of the lobe, out at the north-east corner. Mud Lake lies immediately south
Fish	Panfish, largemouth bass, smallmouth bass and northern pike (all common), walleye (present)
Access	No municipal ramp. Carry-in public access in the Town of Merton; a DNR fishing pier and small-craft launch have been planned. Verify what exists and what it costs before you tow anything. Practically, this is a canoe, kayak or car-top lake



Depth in feet. Schematic — not for navigation. Redrawn from the Wisconsin Conservation Department lake survey sheet (data 1898, revised 21 October 1941; WBIC 850800), published by the Wisconsin DNR as a public document. Contours are reconstructed from that survey’s soundings and are generalized; a survey that old will not match a modern sonar log in detail.  under 5 ft  shoreline  5 & 10 ft  20 ft  30 ft  40 & 60 ft  70 ft  spot

The seven spots, by season

#	Spot	When & what	How
1	North-end flat	Apr–Jun panfish, largemouth, pike; Dec–Feb panfish under ice.	The broad shallow end of the main basin, under 30 ft nearly all the way across. Weed flats that warm first. Slip bobber at 4–10 ft; spinnerbait over the tops for pike.
2	North-east outlet corner	Apr–May and Sep–Nov pike and panfish.	Where the lake drains to the river. Moving water concentrates baitfish and the things that eat them. Fish the current seam. Quick-strike rig with a big sucker; jig-and-minnow on the edge.
3	East shoreline drop	Jun–Sep smallmouth and walleye; Oct pike.	The main basin’s east side falls off steadily to the 78 ft hole. Work the 15–30 ft band. Drop-shot, or a lindy rig dragged along the contour.
4	South-end shoal complex	May–Oct , everything.	Hard humps topping out near 4 ft with deep water all around — the best structure in the lake. Smallmouth and walleye stack on the edges; pike patrol the tops. Start shallow at dawn, work down to 20–25 ft by mid-morning.
5	The neck	All open water. Pike, bass, walleye, panfish.	The only connection between the two basins: a shallow, current-swept bottleneck. Everything that moves between basins passes through. Anchor off the edge and let bait sit; or cast a jig across and swing it with the current.
6	River inlet, west end of the lobe	Mar–May and Oct–Nov pike; panfish and bass in summer.	Incoming river water, warmest in spring and coldest in fall. Stained and weedy. Pike stage here before and after the spawn. Big bait, slow.
7	South shore of the lobe	Jun–Sep bass and panfish deep; Jul–Aug suspended fish.	A short, steep drop into the lobe’s own 78 ft hole. Fish the 12–25 ft break; in high summer look for fish suspended off the edge rather than on it.

How North Lake differs from Pine Lake

If you fish both, do not carry one lake’s habits to the other.	
Fish shallower	Stained water means the weed line ends around 8–12 ft instead of 15–20 ft. The whole food chain moves up with it.
Fish later	Low-light advantage is smaller here. A cloudy mid-morning on North Lake can beat dawn.
Fish heavier	You can get away with heavier line, bigger baits and visible hardware. Save the fluorocarbon and the finesse for Pine.
Two lakes	Each basin has its own population behaviour. If the main basin is dead, cross the neck and fish the lobe — it is a different water.
The river matters	Spring warm-up, fall cool-down and after heavy rain, the inflow and outflow are the first places to look.
Getting there	No trailer ramp. That is why it stays quiet, and it is the best reason to fish it.

CHECK THE REGULATIONS BEFORE EVERY TRIP

The 2026–27 rules for this water are the same as Pine Lake’s: largemouth and smallmouth bass 14 in minimum, 5 per day, 2 May–7 March, catch-and-release the rest of the year; walleye 18 in minimum, 3 per day; northern pike 26 in minimum, 2 per day; muskellunge 40 in minimum, 1 per day, open water only through 31 December; panfish 25 per day; cisco and whitefish 10 per day. **These change.** The Wisconsin DNR publishes the current rules for this exact water body, and only that publication is authoritative.

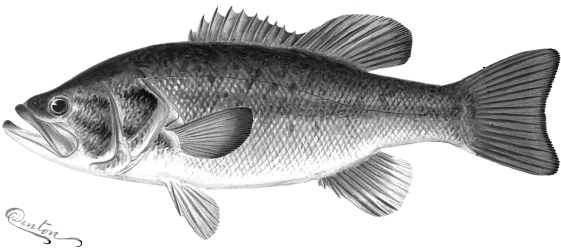
II Species

One page each. How to tell it apart from the fish it gets confused with, where it lives in this lake, when it spawns, and how to catch it. The plates are public-domain chromolithographs by S. F. Denton, published in the New York fisheries reports around 1896–1902.

Largemouth Bass

Micropterus salmoides

The weed-edge ambusher — Pine Lake & North Lake



The Large-Mouthed Black Bass — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart

Size here

Spawn

Eats

Season

Time of day

The jaw. On a largemouth the upper jaw reaches *past* the back of the eye; on a smallmouth it stops under the eye. Largemouth are green with one ragged dark stripe down the side, and the dorsal fin is pinched almost in two.

12–16 in is a normal fish, 18 in is a good one, 20 in is a trophy for these lakes. State record 11 lb 3 oz.

Beds in 1–4 ft of sand or gravel in protected bays when the water holds 60–65 °F — late May into June. The male fans the bed and guards the fry for weeks afterward.

Anything it can fit: bluegill, perch, crayfish, frogs, young of its own kind.

J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
Dawn		Mid		Dusk		Night					

Where

- Pine**

North

Structure

Spots **5** (west shelf), **6** (west bay), **7** (south-east bay). The water is so clear that the weed line runs to 15–20 ft, and so does the bass. Do not stop fishing at 8 ft because that is where you would stop on a normal lake.

Spots **1, 4, 5, 7**. Stained water pulls them shallow — 4–10 ft is the band.

Weed edges, isolated weed clumps, fallen wood, docks, and any hard-to-soft bottom transition. A largemouth wants something to hide behind and open water to charge into.

How

- Search**

In the weeds

Pressured or clear

Deep

First and last light

For a beginner

Spinnerbait or a squarebill crankbait along the weed edge to find active fish fast, then slow down and pick the area apart.

Texas-rigged plastic worm or creature bait, *see the **Texas rig** sheet*. Weedless, sinks slowly, comes through everything.

Weightless wacky-rigged worm, *see the **wacky rig** sheet*. On Pine Lake in bright sun this out-fishes everything else.

A jig-and-craw or a Carolina rig on the outside weed edge, *see the **Carolina rig** sheet*.

A walking topwater or a popper over the weed tops. The best half hour of the day.

A nightcrawler under a slip bobber set to hang just above the weeds. It is not fancy and it works.

The one thing to remember

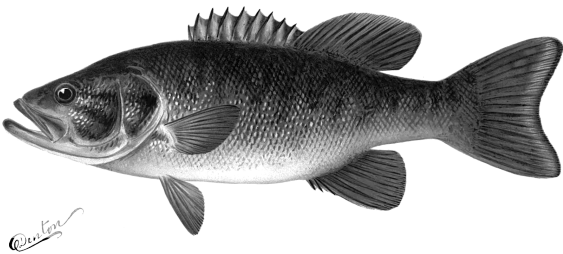
Largemouth relate to *cover*, not depth. Find the edge — of the weeds, of the shade, of the drop — and fish it. In the middle of a featureless flat there is no bass.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 14 in minimum, 5 per day, open 2 May–7 March. Catch-and-release open all year. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Smallmouth Bass

Rock, gravel and hard bottom — Pine Lake & North Lake

Micropterus dolomieu



The Small-Mouthed Black Bass — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart

Size here

Spawn

Eats

Season

Time of day

Bronze rather than green, with dark *vertical* bars instead of one horizontal stripe, and a red or orange eye. The upper jaw stops under the eye. The dorsal fin is one continuous fin, not pinched.

12–17 in typical; 18 in and up is a strong fish. State record 9 lb 1 oz. Pound for pound the hardest-fighting fish in either lake.

Gravel and rubble in 3–10 ft at 60–65 °F, a little later and deeper than largemouth. Pine Lake’s 90% gravel bottom is close to ideal smallmouth habitat.

Crayfish above all, then minnows, perch fry and insect larvae. Match the crayfish and you are most of the way there.

J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
Dawn			Mid		Dusk			Night			

Where

- Pine

North

Structure

Season
- This is a smallmouth lake. Spots **2** (north-east breaks), **3** (east wall), **4** (the mid-lake bar) and **8**. The bar is the best smallmouth spot in the county on a good October morning.

Spots **3** and **4**. The south-end shoal complex is the equivalent of Pine’s bar.

Hard bottom with a fast change in depth. Rock points, gravel bars, rip-rap, boulder fields. If your jig comes back scuffed, you are in the right place.

Shallow and aggressive in May–June, deep and moody in July–August, then shallow and violent again in late September and October.

How

- Best all-round

Deep and finicky

Cold water

Live bait

Line
- A tube jig dragged and hopped on the bottom. It looks exactly like a fleeing crayfish and nothing else is needed most days.

Drop-shot with a small minnow-shaped plastic, *see the **drop-shot** sheet*. This is how you fish Pine Lake’s east wall in August.

A suspending jerkbait, worked with long pauses. In 45–55 °F water the pause is the whole presentation.

A live crayfish or a large leech on a plain hook with one split shot, *see the **split shot** sheet*. Deadly and simple.

Fluorocarbon on Pine Lake. The water is clear enough that it matters.

The one thing to remember

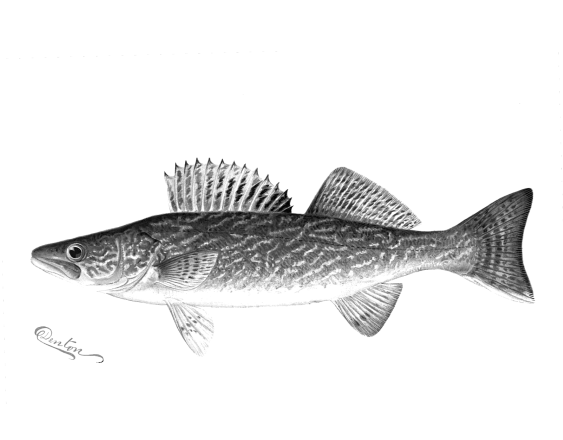
Smallmouth live where the bottom is hard. Largemouth live where the cover is soft. On the same lake, on the same day, that one distinction sorts almost every spot.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 14 in minimum, 5 per day, open 2 May–7 March. Catch-and-release open all year. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Walleye

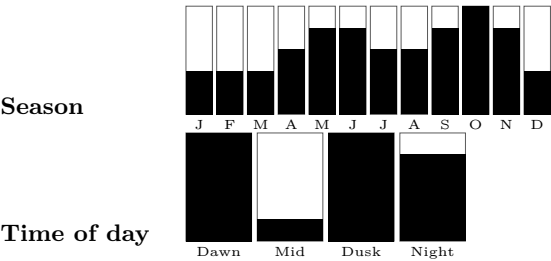
The low-light specialist — Pine Lake & North Lake

Sander vitreus



The Pike Perch or Wall-Eyed Pike — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

- Tell it apart** A **white tip on the lower lobe of the tail** and a dark blotch at the rear base of the spiny dorsal fin. The eye is large and glassy — a reflective layer behind the retina lets it see in water too dark for its prey. Long canine teeth.
- Not a sauger** Sauger have rows of black spots on the spiny dorsal, dark saddles, and no white tail tip. Not expected here, but worth knowing.
- Size here** 15–22 in. The 18 in minimum means most fish you catch go back. State record 18 lb.
- Spawn** Earliest of the gamefish after pike: 42–50 °F, late March into April, over rock and gravel shorelines and in inflows. Pine Lake is stocked with large fingerlings in alternate years.



Where

- Pine** Spots **3** (east wall), **4** (the bar) and **8**. In high summer they may suspend over the basin following cisco — do not assume they are on the bottom.
- North** Spots **3**, **4** (south-end shoals) and **5** (the neck). Stained water means they will be shallower than on Pine.
- Depth** The 18–30 ft break most of the year. Shallower at dawn, dusk and after dark; deeper in bright calm.
- Weather** Grey and windy is a walleye day. Wind on a point breaks up the light and pushes bait against structure — fish the windy side.

How

- Classic** Lindy rig with a leech, half a crawler, or a small minnow, dragged slowly along the contour, *see the lindy rig sheet*. Slow means slower than you think.
- Cold water** Jig-and-minnow, *see the jig-and-minnow sheet*, worked with tiny lifts. Most bites feel like weight, not a strike.
- Covering water** Troll a deep crankbait along the break. Motor trolling is allowed here, up to three hooks, baits or lures per angler.
- Steep faces** A three-way rig holds a precise depth where a lindy rig will not, *see the three-way rig sheet*.
- Timing** The last forty minutes of light beat the rest of the day. Be on the spot before the sun goes.

The one thing to remember

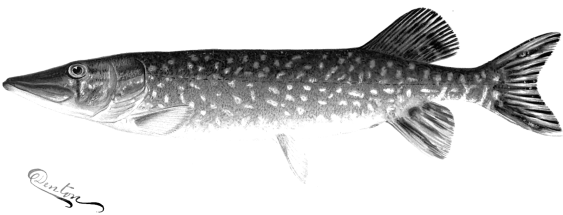
Walleye are not hard to catch; they are hard to be present for. Their eyes give them an advantage in dim light, so they feed when you would rather be at the landing. Fish the edges of the day.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 18 in minimum, 3 per day, open 2 May–7 March. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Northern Pike

Esox lucius

First to spawn, last to quit — Pine Lake & North Lake



The Pike — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart	Light bean-shaped spots on a dark green body — light-on-dark. The cheek is fully scaled and the lower half of the gill cover is bare. Five sensory pores along each side of the lower jaw.																								
Not a musky	A musky is the photographic negative: <i>dark</i> marks on a <i>light</i> body, the lower half of both the cheek and gill cover bare, and six to nine pores per side. At a 40 in minimum on musky and 26 in on pike, this matters.																								
Size here	20–30 in is the working range; 36 in and up is a real fish. State record 38 lb.																								
Spawn	The first gamefish to go, immediately after ice-out at 40–45 °F, in flooded marsh grass and shallow vegetation — often before the ice is fully gone from the main lake.																								
Season	<table><tr><td>J</td><td>F</td><td>M</td><td>A</td><td>M</td><td>J</td><td>J</td><td>A</td><td>S</td><td>O</td><td>N</td><td>D</td></tr><tr><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td></tr></table>	J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■
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Where

Pine	Spots 1 and 9 in spring and fall, 5 along the deep weed edge in summer. In a lake this cold and clear, the largest pike go deep and cool in July and August — 25–40 ft on the edge of the basin, not in the shallows.
North	Spots 2 (outlet), 5 (the neck) and 6 (river inlet). Current and weed. This lake fishes more like a classic pike water than Pine does.
Cover	Weed edges, points, and any narrows. Pike are ambush hunters that want a wall at their back and open water in front.

How

Cover water	A large spinnerbait or a spoon over and along the weed tops. Fast, snag-resistant, and it finds the aggressive fish.
Big fish	A large sucker on a quick-strike rig under a float, <i>see the quick-strike rig sheet</i> . This is how most of the biggest pike in these lakes are taken.
Ice	Tip-ups with a live shiner set just off the bottom along the weed edge, <i>see the tip-up sheet</i> .
Leader	Always. A wire or heavy fluorocarbon leader. Pike teeth cut straight line, and losing a fish with a hook in it is a bad outcome for the fish, not just for you.

HANDLING A PIKE

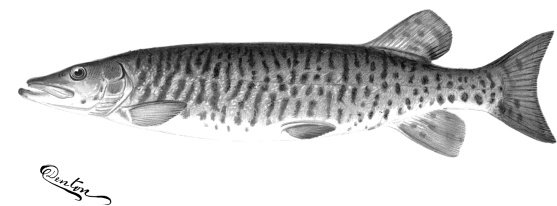
The teeth are backward-facing and will cut you to the bone. Long pliers and jaw spreaders, always; fingers never go in the mouth or under the gill plate. Support a big fish horizontally with a wet hand under the belly. Above roughly 70 °F a released pike is fragile — unhook it in the net, in the water, and let it go.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 26 in minimum, 2 per day, open 2 May–7 March. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Muskellunge

Esox masquinongy

An incidental fish here — but know it on sight



The Mascalonge — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Pattern	Dark bars or spots on a <i>light</i> body — the exact reverse of a northern pike.
Cheek	Lower half of <i>both</i> the cheek and the gill cover is scaleless.
Jaw pores	Six to nine per side. A pike has five or fewer.
Tail	Lobes come to sharper points than a pike's.
Minimum	40 in, 1 per day, open water only.

Why this sheet exists
Muskellunge are not among the species the DNR lists as common in Pine Lake or North Lake. They are nonetheless regulated on both waters, at a 40 in minimum and one fish per day. If you hook a large esocid here it is almost certainly a northern pike — but you must be able to prove that to yourself before you decide what to do with it, because the two fish carry different minimum lengths and different seasons.

Musky or pike? Three checks, in order

1. Pattern	Musky: dark bars or spots on a light background. Pike: light bean-shaped spots on a dark background. The two are photographic negatives of one another.
2. Cheek & gill cover	Look at the side of the head. Musky: the lower half of <i>both</i> the cheek and the gill cover is scaleless. Pike: the whole cheek is scaled; only the lower gill cover is bare.
3. Jaw pores	Turn the head and count the pores along one side of the underside of the lower jaw. Musky: six to nine. Pike: five or fewer. This is the check that settles an argument.
Tail	A musky's tail lobes come to sharper points; a pike's are more rounded. Useful as confirmation, not as the deciding test.
Tiger musky	A pike-musky hybrid, with bold wavy bars and rounded tail lobes. It falls under the musky regulations.

If you do hook one

Decide fast	Measure it in the net, in the water. Under 40 in it goes back, full stop.
Gear	A big musky cannot be landed responsibly on panfish tackle. A large net, long pliers, jaw spreaders and bolt cutters for a buried hook are the minimum.
Release	Keep it horizontal and in the water. A musky is a long, heavy fish and its own weight in air injures it. Revive it facing into the current or move it gently forward until it swims off under its own power.
Season	Open water only, 2 May–31 December — unlike pike, there is no ice season for musky.

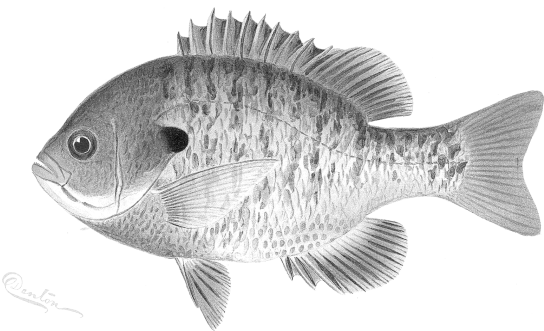
Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 40 in minimum, 1 per day, open water only, 2 May–31 December. A misidentified fish is still a violation. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR's current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Muskellunge. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Bluegill

Lepomis macrochirus

The best fish in the lake to learn on



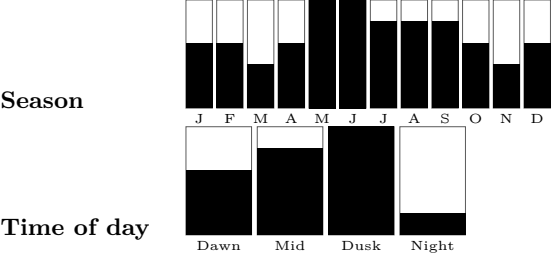
Blue Gill Sun Fish — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart A solid black ear flap with no coloured margin, a dark smudge at the rear base of the soft dorsal fin, a small mouth, and long pointed pectoral fins. Compare with the pumpkinseed, which has an orange-red spot on the flap and wavy blue lines on the cheek.

Size here 6–8 in is a good fish; a 9 in bluegill is a genuine trophy and worth releasing so it keeps breeding.

Spawn 67–70 °F, late May into June, in dense colonies of saucer-shaped beds on sand or gravel in 1–4 ft. You can see the beds from the boat and often smell them.

Eats Insect larvae, small crustaceans, snails. A small mouth means small baits.



Where

- Pine** Spots **6** (west bay) and **1** on the beds in June, then out to the deep weed edge at **5** — 12–18 ft — for the rest of the summer. Bluegill on Pine go deeper than most people expect.
- North** Spots **1** and **7**, and the weed flats generally. 4–10 ft.
- Winter** Basin edges and remaining green weed at 10–20 ft. Bays **6** on Pine, **1** on North.

How

- The rig** A slip bobber, a small split shot, and a size 8 or 10 hook, *see the slip bobber sheet*. Set the depth so the bait rides just above the weed tops.
- Bait** A piece of nightcrawler — not a whole one — a waxworm, a leaf worm, or a small leech. Bluegill have small mouths and will strip a big bait without ever getting hooked.
- Artificial** A 1/32 oz jig with a small plastic tail, or a small foam spider on a fly rod during the June bed period.
- Line** 4lb. Anything heavier telegraphs badly on a small float and costs you bites.
- With a child** This is the fish. Anchor over a bed in June, use a fixed bobber a foot or two deep, and expect constant action. Barbless or pinched barbs make unhooking fast and safe.

Fish the beds gently

Bedding bluegill are easy to catch and easy to strip out of a bay. Take a meal, not a cooler. The biggest males guard the beds, and removing them all is how a lake ends up full of stunted four-inch fish.

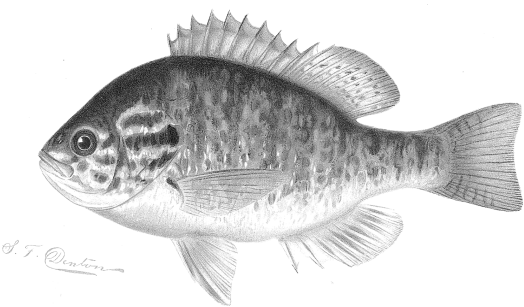
Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. Panfish: 25 per day in total, open all year, no minimum length. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR's current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Bluegill. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

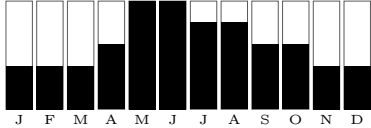
Pumpkinseed

The other sunfish on the bed

Lepomis gibbosus



Sunfish (*Eupomotis gibbosus*) — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart	An orange-red spot on the trailing edge of the black ear flap, and wavy pale-blue lines radiating back across the cheek and gill cover. The fins are speckled. There is <i>no</i> dark blotch at the back of the soft dorsal — that blotch belongs to the bluegill.
Shape	Rounder and deeper-bodied than a bluegill, with a slightly larger mouth and shorter, more rounded pectoral fins.
Size here	5–7 in. Rarely as large as a good bluegill, and usually a smaller share of the catch.
Spawn	Same window as bluegill, 65–70 °F, often on the same colonial beds — and the two species hybridize, which is why you will occasionally land something that fits neither description.
Eats	Snails above all — it has crushing teeth in its throat for them — plus insect larvae and small crustaceans.
Season	

Where and how

Habitat	Shallower and weedier than bluegill, and more tied to cover. Pine spots 6 and 1 ; North spots 1 and 7 .
Depth	1–8 ft, in and against vegetation. If you are catching bluegill on the deep weed edge and pumpkinseed on the inside edge, that is normal.
Rig	Identical to bluegill — slip bobber, split shot, size 8 or 10 hook, small piece of worm. <i>see the slip bobber sheet</i>
Counts as	Panfish, under the 25 per day aggregate limit.

Worth knowing on the bed

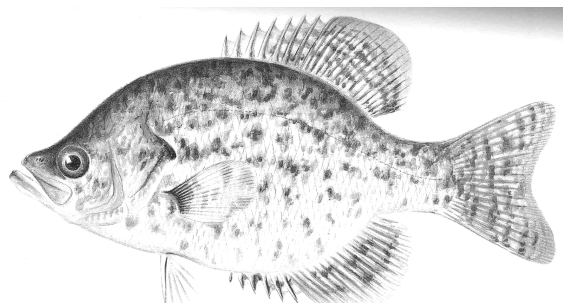
When you find a June sunfish colony you will usually be catching both species plus the occasional hybrid. Sorting them on the spot is a good five-minute lesson for a child: flip the gill cover into the light and look for the orange dot.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Pumpkinseed. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Black Crappie

A roaming, suspending, low-light panfish

Pomoxis nigromaculatus



Calico Bass; Strawberry Bass (*Pomoxis sparoides*) — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart

The paper mouth

Size here

Spawn

Eats

Season

Time of day

Count the dorsal spines: seven or eight on a black crappie, five or six on a white crappie. The speckling is scattered and irregular, not organised into vertical bars. The body is deep, thin and silvery.

The membrane around the jaw tears easily. Do not set hard and do not lift a crappie by the line — this is the fish people lose at the side of the boat.

8–11 in. A 12 in crappie is a very good fish.

58–64 °F, May, in 3–8 ft near brush, wood or the inside weed edge. Slightly earlier and slightly deeper than bluegill.

Small minnows and zooplankton. More fish-eating than the sunfish, which is why a minnow beats a worm.

Month	Dawn	Mid	Dusk	Night
J	High	Low	Low	Low
F	High	Low	Low	Low
M	High	Low	Low	Low
A	High	Low	Low	Low
M	High	Low	Low	Low
J	High	Low	High	Low
J	High	Low	High	Low
A	High	Low	High	Low
S	High	Low	High	Low
O	High	Low	High	Low
N	High	Low	High	Low
D	High	Low	High	Low

Where

- Pine**

North

The key habit

Spot **7** (south-east bay) and **6** in spring; the edges of the mid-lake bar **4** in summer, where they suspend off the drop.

Spots **1** and **4**, and anywhere with standing wood.

Crappie **suspend**. They roam in schools at a chosen depth over deep water, ignoring the bottom entirely. Finding the depth matters far more than finding the spot.

How

- Find the depth**

Best bait

Artificial

Hookset

When

Cast a small jig, count it down — five, ten, fifteen — and retrieve. When you get bit, remember the count and repeat it exactly.

A small live minnow under a slip bobber, *see the **slip bobber sheet***, set precisely at the depth you found. Crappie feed *upward*; set the bait slightly above them, never below.

1/16 or 1/32 oz jig with a soft plastic tail, in white or chartreuse. Barely move it.

A steady sweep, not a snap. Paper mouth.

Dusk is the crappie hour. They also feed well in the first hour of an overcast morning and through the ice in January.

The one thing to remember

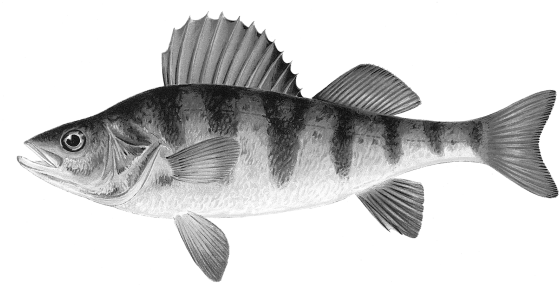
If you are catching nothing, change your *depth* before you change your bait. A school two feet below your jig will not come up for it, and a school two feet above it never sees it.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. Panfish: 25 per day in total, open all year, no minimum length. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR's current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Yellow Perch

Perca flavescens

A daylight schooling fish — and the walleye’s opposite



Yellow or Barred Perch — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart

Size here

Spawn

Eats

Six to eight dark **vertical bars** over a yellow-green body, with orange lower fins. Two separate dorsal fins, the first spiny. Unmistakable.

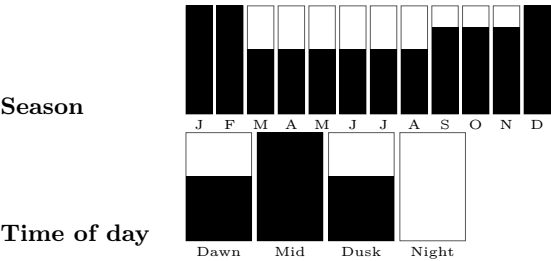
6–10 in. A 10 in perch is a fine fish and among the best eating in either lake.

45–52 °F, April, and unlike any other fish here the female lays a long accordion-folded ribbon of eggs draped over weeds and brush. You will see them in the shallows.

Insect larvae, small crustaceans, minnows and fish eggs. Perch are also the primary food of walleye and pike — which is exactly why they school.

Habit

A daytime feeder. Perch shut down at night, when walleye switch on. They travel in tight schools on the bottom.



Where

Pine

North

Bottom

Winter

The deep weed edge at spot **5**, the flats around the base of the bar **4**, and the 15–30 ft bottom generally.

Spots **1**, **3** and **4**. Shallower than on Pine because of the stain.

Perch stay on or near the bottom on clean sand, gravel or the base of weeds. If you are more than a foot off the bottom you are fishing over them.

One of the best ice fish in either lake, on the same 15–30 ft flats.

How

Best rig

Move to find them

Stay on them

Eating

A small jig tipped with a minnow head, a piece of crawler or a waxworm, fished right on the bottom. Or a drop-shot with a very short tag, *see the **drop-shot** sheet*.

Perch schools are tight. If you catch two and then nothing, the school moved — move with it rather than waiting.

When you find a school, drop straight back down immediately. A hooked fish drags the school with it and a slow re-bait costs you the whole group.

Excellent — firm, white, mild. This is the fish worth keeping a limit of.

The lesson to teach

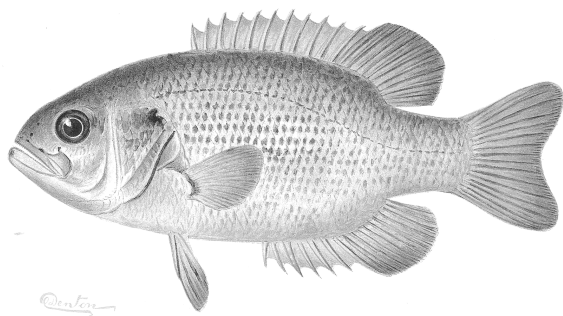
Perch and walleye eat the same food in the same water but never at the same hour: one has eyes built for daylight, the other for dusk. That single fact explains most of the daily rhythm of both lakes.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. Panfish: 25 per day in total, open all year, no minimum length. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Rock Bass

Red-eyed, abundant, and always willing

Ambloplites rupestris



Rock Bass — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart	A bright red eye , a large mouth for a panfish, and rows of dark spots along the scale lines giving a dotted-stripe look. The clinching check: six spines in the anal fin . Bluegill, pumpkinseed and the other sunfish have three.
Colour	It can flush from pale olive to near-black in seconds, so colour alone will mislead you. Use the eye and the anal spines.
Size here	6–9 in. Abundant on Pine Lake, whose gravel bottom is exactly what they want.
Spawn	Late May into June at 60–70 °F, in shallow nests scooped on gravel near rock, often close to smallmouth beds.
Eats	Crayfish, insect larvae and small fish. Aggressive well out of proportion to its size.
Season	

Where and how

Habitat	Rock, gravel, rip-rap and boulder. Pine spots 2, 3, 4 and 8 ; North spots 3 and 4 . Wherever you fish for smallmouth you will find rock bass first.
Depth	2–20 ft, tight to the bottom and tight to cover.
Rig	They will take anything. A split-shot rig with a worm, a small jig, a tube — it hardly matters. <i>see the split shot sheet</i>
Counts as	Panfish, under the 25 per day aggregate limit.
Eating	Perfectly good — white and mild, if a little softer than perch. Under-appreciated.

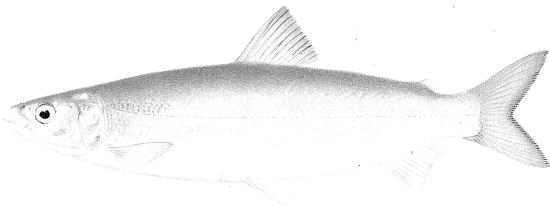
Use them
Rock bass are the fish that saves a slow morning with a child, and they are the fish that tells you your smallmouth spot has the right bottom. Neither is a small thing. If you are catching rock bass on a new piece of structure, keep working it.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Rock Bass. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See **LICENSE** and **CREDITS.md** in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Cisco

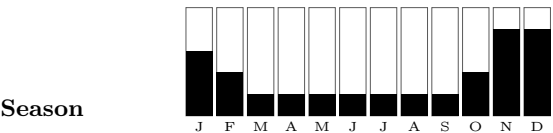
Coregonus artedii — also called lake herring

The deep-water forage fish that explains Pine Lake



Cisco from Hemlock Lake (*Argyrosomus artedii*) — plate from the Freshwater and Marine Image Bank, University of Washington. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart	Slim, bright silver, deeply forked tail, small toothless mouth, and a small fleshy adipose fin between the dorsal and the tail — the mark of a salmonid. Nothing else in these lakes has one.
Size here	8–14 in.
Why it matters	Cisco need cold water that still holds oxygen through the summer. Very few lakes in south-eastern Wisconsin can supply that. Their presence is a direct statement about the quality and depth of Pine Lake’s basin.
Spawn	Very late — November into December, over shallow gravel, often as the lake is cooling toward ice.
Eats	Zooplankton, out in open water. It is a pelagic fish that almost never touches bottom or structure.



What it means for your fishing

Suspended predators	Through July and August, cisco hold in the cold layer below the thermocline over Pine Lake’s 60–85 ft basin, and the biggest walleye, pike and smallmouth follow them out there. This is why the structure bite can die in high summer while the lake is still full of large fish — they are not on the structure at all.
What to do about it	Watch your electronics over open water between spots 3 and 4 . Marks at 30–45 ft over 70 ft of water in August are usually cisco, and often something larger nearby.
Bait size	Where predators are eating a 10 in silver fish, a 3 in minnow is a poor imitation. Size up in late summer.
Catching them	Mostly incidental. They will take a small jig or spoon fished deep, and they are a known ice-fishing target on lakes that hold them. 10 per day; open all year.
Eating	Excellent, oily and fine-textured. Traditionally smoked.

A lesson in the lake

A lake is a stack of layers, not a bowl. In summer Pine Lake has warm water on top, a sharp temperature step in the middle, and cold water below — and different fish live in each. Cisco are the clearest evidence that the bottom layer is alive. Explaining that to a child on the water is worth more than a limit of bluegill.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Cisco. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See **LICENSE** and **CREDITS.md** in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

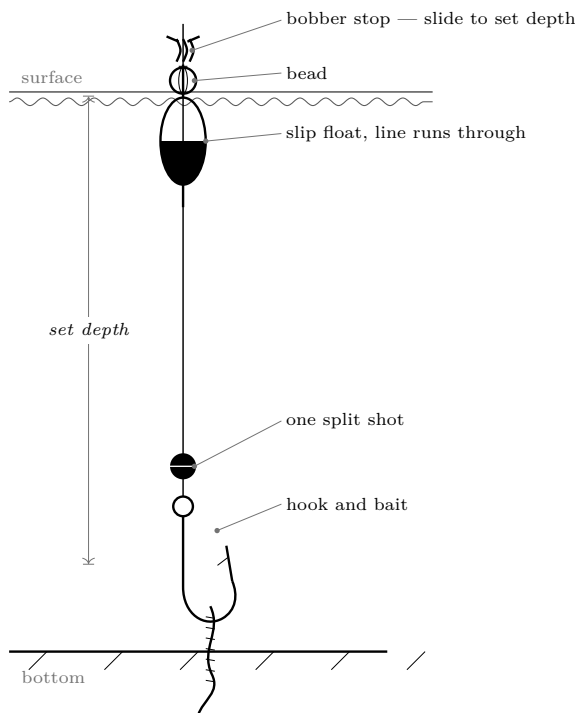
III Rigs

One page each: a drawing of the assembled rig, what every component is for, how to build it, and how to fish it. Roughly in order of how often you will tie them.

Slip Bobber

Hold a live bait at an exact depth, in any depth of water

The first rig to learn and the last one to give up



What it does	The float slides freely on the line until it hits the stop knot. You can fish 20 ft down and still reel the float to the rod tip to cast.
Why it matters	A fixed bobber can only fish as deep as your rod is long. A slip float has no such limit, which is the whole reason it exists.
Components	Bobber stop (thread or rubber), small bead, slip float, one or two split shot, hook.
Hook	Size 8–10 for panfish, 4–6 for crappie on a minnow, 1/0 for bass or walleye on a leech.
Line	4 lb for panfish; 6–8 lb for bass and walleye.
Catches	Bluegill, pumpkinseed, crappie, perch, largemouth, walleye, pike.

Build it

1. Thread the **bobber stop** onto the main line and slide it up. Tighten it enough to hold but loose enough to slide when you pull — this is what you will adjust all day.
2. Thread the **bead**. Its only job is to stop the small stop knot from pulling through the float's hole.
3. Thread the **float**, top end first.
4. Pinch on **split shot** 8–12 in above where the hook will be. Enough weight that the float sits upright with only its tip showing — an over-floated bobber cannot signal a bite.
5. Tie on the **hook** with an improved clinch knot, *see the **knots** sheet*.

Fish it

Set the depth	Bait should ride just above whatever the fish are holding on — the weed tops, the bottom, the school. Fish look up far more readily than down. Start a foot above and work down.
Read it	A bluegill takes the float sideways and down in small taps. A crappie lifts it and lays it flat — that is a fish swimming up with the bait, and it is a bite. Walleye pull it under slowly and steadily.
Set the hook	Reel the slack, then sweep. Do not snap a rod at a crappie, <i>see the Black Crappie sheet</i> .
Adjust	A float that lies flat and stays flat is too deep — the bait is on the bottom. Slide the stop down.

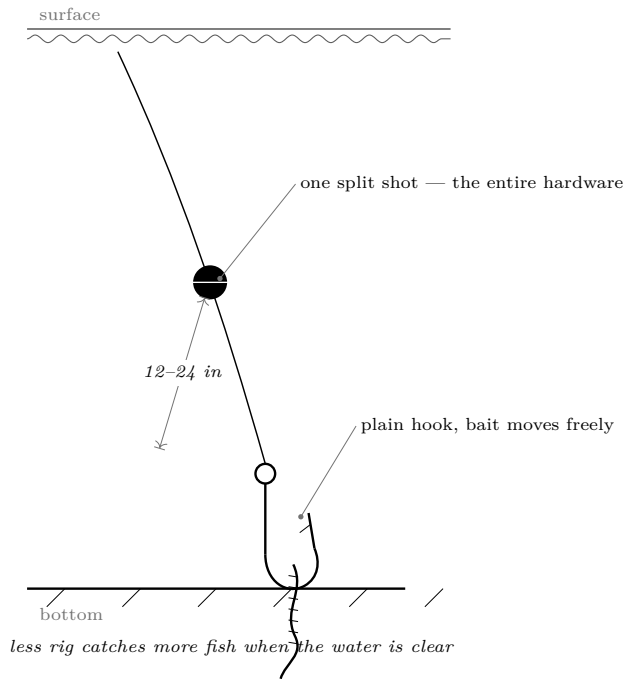
When to use it

Any time you know the depth and want the bait to stay there: over a weed edge, over a crappie school suspended at 14 ft, over a bluegill bed, or with a big sucker over a weed flat for pike. It is the most controllable live-bait presentation there is, and it is the easiest rig in this guide to hand to a beginner.

Split Shot Rig

A hook, a pinch of lead, and nothing else

The least rig you can get away with — and often the best



What it does	One small weight pinched on the line 12–24 in above a plain hook. It gives just enough weight to cast and to sink, and leaves the bait free to move naturally.
Why it matters	Every other rig on these sheets adds hardware, and hardware adds unnatural motion. When fish are wary, less rig catches more fish.
Components	A hook. A split shot. That is all.
Shot size	BB or size 5 for panfish; size 3 or larger, or two shot, for bass and smallmouth in deeper water.
Removable shot	Buy the kind with wings on the back so you can reopen and reposition them. You will move the shot constantly.
Catches	Everything. Rock bass, perch, bluegill, smallmouth on a live crayfish, walleye on a leech.

Fish it

1. Pinch one shot on the line, using pliers or your teeth — but never on fluorocarbon leader you care about, because crimping weakens it at that point.
2. Cast out and let it sink on a semi-tight line, watching where the line enters the water.
3. Retrieve in slow, small pulls with long pauses, or simply let it sit on the bottom and wait.
4. Move the shot to change how the bait behaves: closer to the hook makes it sink faster and act tighter, further away lets it drift and swim more freely.

Where it beats a better rig

Wary fish	Pine Lake in flat calm. A single small shot is less unnatural than a jig head or a bullet weight.
Live crayfish	Hook one through the tail with a plain hook and one shot, and drift it across gravel at Pine spots 2, 3 or 4 . Very few smallmouth refuse it.
Teaching	Two components and no rigging. A child can build it in twenty seconds and understand what every part does.
Repair	When you snap off the fancy rig in a rock pile and the light is going, this is the rig you can retie in the dark.
Not for	Heavy weed — the exposed hook fouls. Use a <i>see the Texas rig sheet</i> there instead.

When to use it

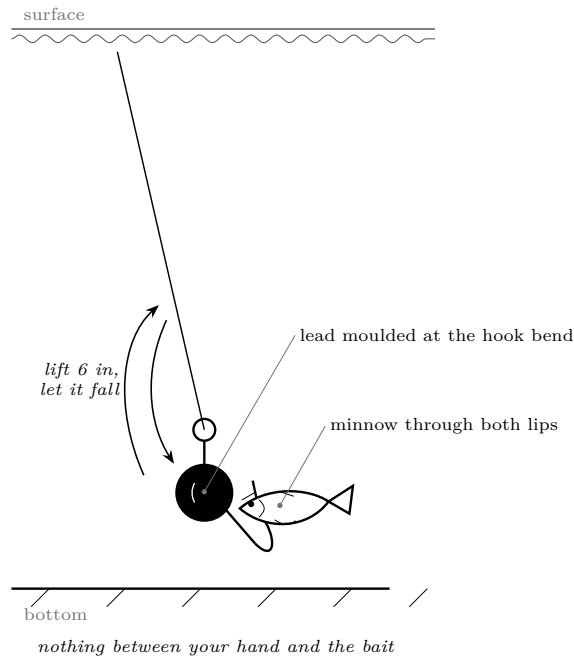
Whenever you catch yourself adding hardware to solve a problem that is actually caused by hardware. Start every unfamiliar spot with a split shot and a piece of live bait: it tells you what lives there before you commit to a technique.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Split Shot Rig. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Jig and Minnow

One hook, one weight, one piece of bait

The simplest way to put a bait exactly where a walleye is



What it does	Weight and hook in one piece, so you feel everything and control the depth absolutely. There is nothing between your hand and the bait.
Why it matters	In cold water a walleye's take is a barely perceptible change in weight. A jig transmits that; almost nothing else does.
Weight	1/8 oz to 15 ft, 1/4 oz to 25 ft, 3/8 oz deeper or in wind. Use the lightest head that still lets you feel bottom.
Head shape	Round for vertical work; a stand-up head for dragging on a clean bottom.
Bait	A 2-3 in fathead or shiner hooked up through both lips. A half crawler or a leech works in warmer water.
Line	6-8 lb. Braid with a fluorocarbon leader if you want maximum feel in deep water.

Fish it

1. Lower or cast, and let it fall on a **semi-tight** line. Watch and feel — a good share of bites happen on the initial drop, and on a fully slack line you will never know.
2. When it hits bottom, lift the rod tip about six inches and **let it fall back under control**, following it down with the rod. The fall is the presentation. The lift only sets up the next fall.
3. Pause on the bottom for a two-count. Repeat.
4. If you are casting, work the jig back with the same lift-and-fall while the boat holds on the contour.

Reading the bite

The classic take	You lift and the jig feels <i>heavy</i> — as though you picked up a wet leaf. That is a walleye. Sweep the rod immediately.
The tick	A single sharp tap on the fall. Set at once.
Nothing	Sometimes the jig simply stops falling early. Set.
Do not snap	A firm upward sweep sets a single sharp hook. A violent snap tears it out of a soft mouth.
Stay vertical	Keep the line as close to straight up and down as the drift allows. Line at an angle costs you feel and costs you hooksets.
Where	Pine spots 2, 3, 4 and 8 ; North spots 2, 3 and 4 . 15-35 ft.

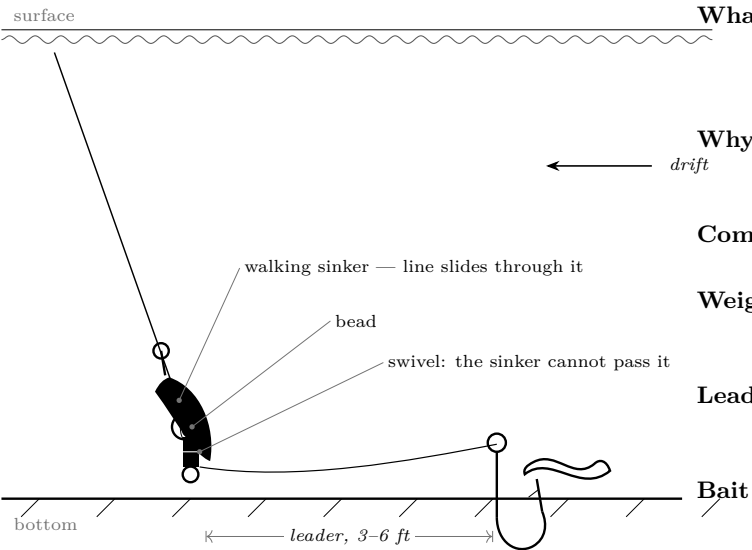
When to use it
Cold water — ice-out through May, and again from October on — and any time you can see fish on electronics and want to put something on their heads. It is also the best rig for teaching feel, because everything that happens to the jig arrives in your hand.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Jig and Minnow. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See **LICENSE** and **CREDITS.md** in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Lindy Rig

Drag live bait along the bottom and let the fish take line

The walleye rig — also called a slip-sinker or live-bait rig



- What it does** The sinker drags the bottom; the line slides *through* it. When a fish picks up the bait it feels no weight at all, so it keeps moving instead of dropping the bait.
- Why it matters** A cold-water walleye mouths a bait and spits anything that resists. This rig removes the resistance.
- Components** Walking or egg sinker, bead, barrel swivel, 3–6 ft leader, single hook.
- Weight** 1/4 oz to 20 ft, 3/8 oz to 30 ft, 1/2 oz deeper or in wind. Use the lightest that keeps bottom contact.
- Leader** Long and light in Pine Lake’s clear water — 6 ft of 6 lb fluorocarbon. Shorter and heavier on North Lake.
- Bait** Leech, half a nightcrawler, or a lively minnow hooked through the lips.

Build it

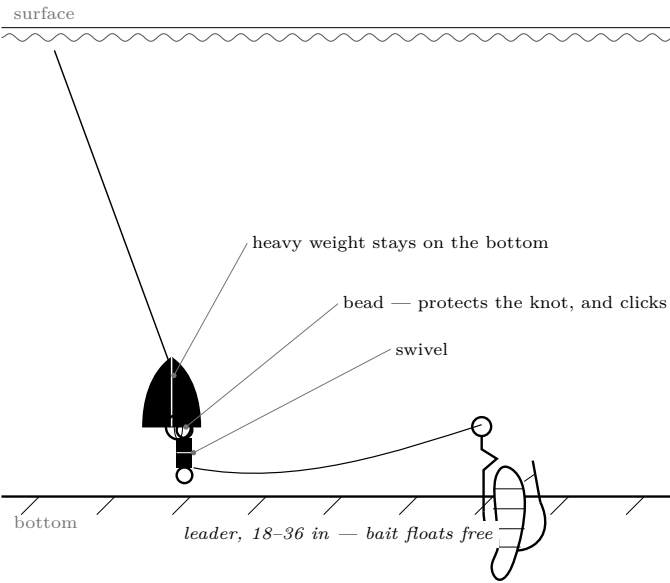
1. Thread the **sinker** onto the main line, narrow end first, so the line runs freely through it.
2. Add a **bead** to protect the knot from the sinker.
3. Tie the main line to one eye of a **barrel swivel**. The swivel is the stop: the sinker rides above it and cannot reach the hook.
4. Tie the **leader** to the other eye, then the **hook** to the leader.

Fish it

- Speed** Slower than feels right. Drift with the wind or use the electric motor at a crawl — roughly the speed you would walk a dog that keeps stopping.
- Contact** You must feel the sinker ticking bottom. If you cannot, add weight; if it is plowing, take weight off.
- The take** You will feel weight, or a tap, or simply nothing where there was bottom a moment ago. **Do not set the hook.**
- Feed it** Open the bail or drop the rod tip and give the fish line for a slow count of five to ten. The fish is turning the bait to swallow it head first.
- Then set** Close the bail, reel until the line comes tight, and sweep the rod. No snap.
- Follow the contour** Keep the boat on one depth line. A walleye break is a line, not a spot.

When to use it
Pine Lake spots 3 and 8 , North Lake spot 3 , in 18–35 ft. It is the highest-percentage way to catch a walleye on either lake, and it doubles as a smallmouth and perch rig. It is also the rig that most rewards patience: the whole thing depends on giving line to a fish that has not yet decided to keep your bait.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Lindy Rig. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.



- What it does**

A heavy weight stays on the bottom and telegraphs exactly what the bottom is made of, while the bait trails behind on a long leader, floating free.
- Versus Texas**

A Texas rig puts the weight *at* the bait; a Carolina rig separates them. Texas gets into cover; Carolina covers ground and keeps the bait visible.
- Components**

3/8–3/4 oz weight, glass or brass bead, barrel swivel, 18–36 in leader, offset hook, soft plastic.
- The bead**

Sits between weight and swivel. It protects the knot and it clicks — an audible attractor on a hard bottom.
- Leader length**

Short (18 in) in cold water or heavy weed; long (36 in) in clear water and on a clean bottom.
- Line**

15 lb main, 10–12 lb leader, so a snag breaks off the bait and not the whole rig.

Build it

1. Thread the **weight** onto the main line, then the **bead**.
2. Tie the main line to a **barrel swivel**.
3. Tie the **leader** to the other end of the swivel, then the **hook** to the leader.
4. Rig the plastic weedless exactly as for a *see the **Texas rig** sheet*, or on an open hook if the bottom is clean.

Fish it

- Cast long**

This is a long-cast rig. The weight carries it, and the long leader means it needs a slow, wide casting stroke or it will tangle.
- Drag, do not hop**

Sweep the rod sideways, low and slow, to drag the weight across the bottom. Reel up the slack, reposition, sweep again.
- Feel the bottom**

You are mapping structure by touch. Sand feels smooth, gravel grinds, rock knocks, weeds load and release. Slow down when the bottom changes — that is where fish are.
- The bite**

Usually a distinct tick or a mushy weight. Reel down until tight, then sweep. Do not snap.
- Where**

Pine spot **5** on the outside weed edge, and the flats around the base of the bar at **4**. North spots **3** and **4**.

When to use it

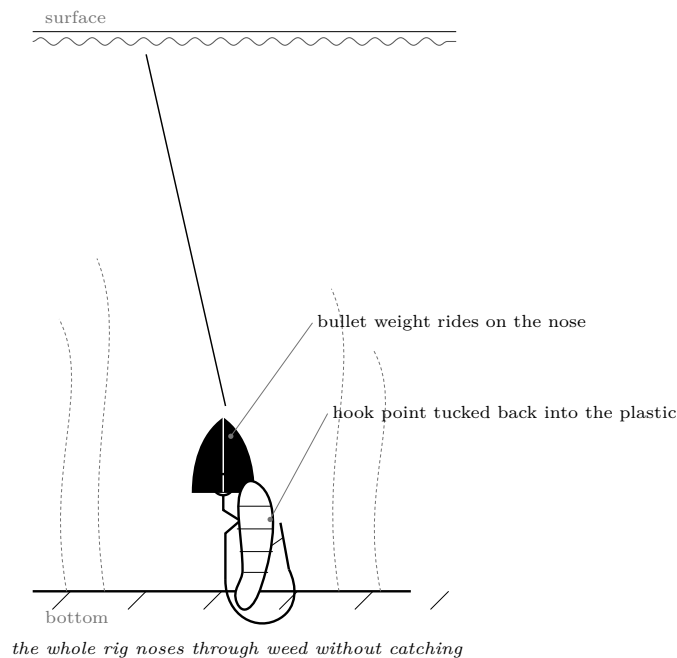
When you need to find fish on a big, featureless-looking flat. The Carolina rig is a search tool that happens to catch fish: it tells you where the bottom changes, and bass live where the bottom changes.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Carolina Rig. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Texas Rig

The weedless bass rig

Put a soft plastic inside heavy cover without hanging up



What it does	A cone-shaped weight slides down to the nose of a soft plastic, and the hook point is tucked back inside the plastic body. The whole thing noses through weed, wood and rock without catching.
Why it matters	Largemouth live inside cover. Any rig that hangs up in cover cannot reach them.
Components	Bullet weight, optional peg or bobber stop, offset worm hook, soft plastic.
Weight	1/8 oz over sparse weed, 1/4–3/8 oz to punch through thick stuff. Lighter falls slower and gets more bites.
Hook	3/0–4/0 offset worm hook for a 6 in worm; 4/0–5/0 for a creature bait.
Line	12–15 lb. You are pulling fish out of salad; this is not the place for 6 lb.

Rig the plastic — this is the whole trick

1. Slide the **bullet weight** on, point first, then tie on the hook. Peg the weight with a bobber stop if you want it to stay at the nose in heavy cover; leave it free to slide if you want the bait to fall away from the weight.
2. Push the hook point into the exact centre of the worm’s nose and out the side after about **1/4 inch**. Not more.
3. Slide the worm up over the hook eye and onto the line.
4. Rotate the hook 180 degrees so the point faces the worm’s body.
5. Lay the hook alongside the worm to see where the point lands, then push it through at that spot and back out — then **pull it back** until the point just sits under the plastic skin. The worm must hang perfectly straight. A worm with a kink in it spins and fish will not eat it.

Fish it

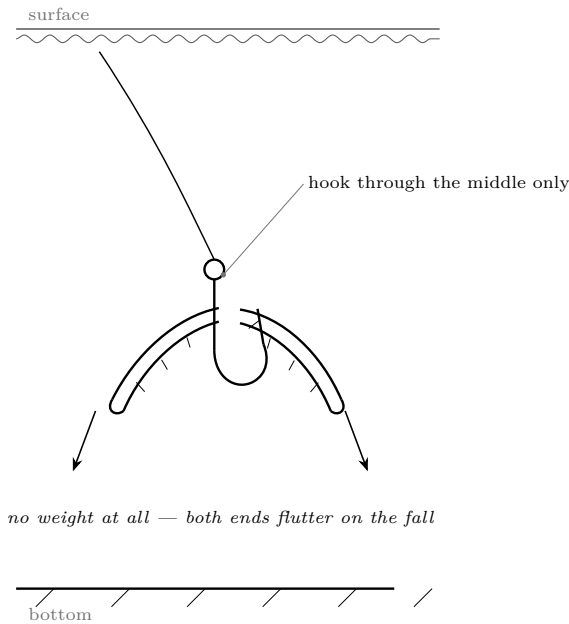
Cast and watch	Most bites come on the initial fall. Watch your line where it enters the water — if it jumps, twitches, or stops falling early, set the hook.
Work it	Lift the rod tip slowly to drag the bait a foot, then let it fall back on a controlled slack line. Repeat. You are feeling for weight, not waiting for a tug.
Set hard	Unlike every other rig on this sheet, this one needs a hard, fast, upward set — you have to drive the point out through the plastic and into bone.
Where	Pine spots 5 and 6 , North spots 1 and 7 . Into the weeds, not along them.

When to use it
When the fish are <i>in</i> cover rather than beside it: matted weed, laydowns, dock pilings, the inside edge of a weed bed on a hot afternoon. If you can fish an open weed edge, a <i>see the Carolina rig sheet</i> covers water faster — but nothing else gets into the thick stuff and comes back out.

Wacky Rig

The clear-water finesse rig

One hook, one worm, no weight — and it out-fishes everything in clear water



What it does	A straight soft-plastic worm hooked through its middle, with no weight at all. On the fall both halves shimmy independently. Nothing else in fishing moves like it.
Why it works	It falls slowly, horizontally, and looks alive while doing nothing. In water as clear as Pine Lake's, a slow horizontal fall beats an active retrieve.
Components	One 1/0 or 2/0 octopus or wide-gap hook, one 5 in stick worm. That is the entire rig.
O-ring	Slide a small rubber O-ring onto the worm's middle and hook under the ring instead of through the plastic. One worm then lasts twenty fish instead of two.
Line	6–10 lb. Spinning tackle. Fluorocarbon leader on Pine Lake.
Catches	Largemouth above all; smallmouth and big bluegill will take it too.

Fish it

1. Cast past the target — a dock, a weed clump, an edge — and **do nothing**.
2. Watch the line. The worm is falling on a slack line and almost every bite happens here. If the line twitches, jumps, or stops falling, reel down and sweep.
3. If it reaches the bottom untouched, give the rod two small shakes, then let it sit for a slow count of five.
4. Lift, let it fall again, and repeat. Retrieve slowly and cast again.

Getting it right

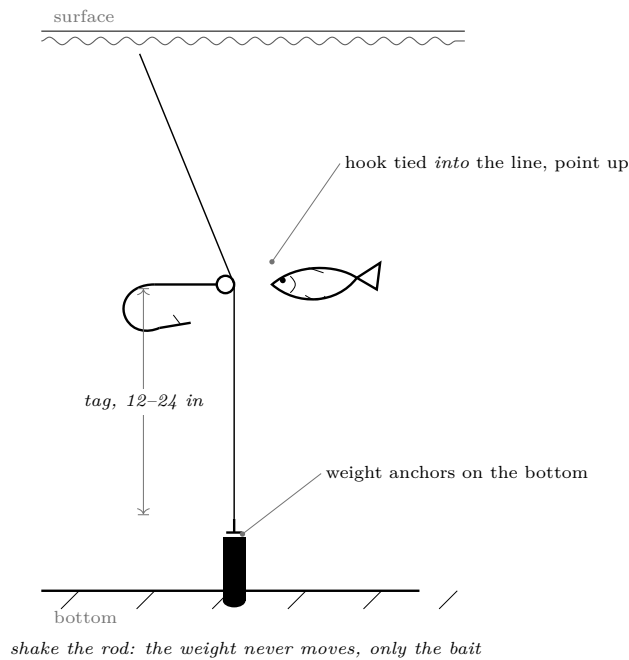
Patience	The single most common mistake is fishing it too fast. This rig catches fish while it is doing nothing. If you feel like you are wasting time, you are probably fishing it correctly.
Watch the line	You will not feel most bites. You will see them. Keep a slight bow in the line and keep your eyes on where it enters the water.
Wind	The one condition it hates. In a chop you cannot see the line; switch to a <i>see the Texas rig sheet</i> or a jig.
Where	Pine spots 5 , 6 and 7 — especially in bright, calm, high-sun conditions when nothing else produces. North spots 1 and 7 .
Hookset	A firm sweep, not a snap. The hook is exposed; it does not need to be driven through plastic.

When to use it
Bright sun, flat calm, clear water, pressured fish — exactly the conditions where everyone else stops catching. On Pine Lake in July this is the highest-percentage bass presentation on the sheet, and it takes ten seconds to tie.

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Drop Shot

Weight on the bottom, bait suspended above it, both under your control



What it does	Everything else puts the weight above the bait. This puts it below. The weight anchors on the bottom and the bait hovers a fixed distance above it, where you can shake it in place indefinitely without moving it.
Why it matters	Fish that will not chase will still eat something that hangs in front of them. This is the rig for a tough day in deep clear water.
Components	Cylinder or teardrop weight, size 1 or 1/0 drop-shot hook, small minnow-shaped plastic.
Tag length	12 in for bottom-hugging perch and smallmouth; 24-36 in for fish suspended off a drop.
Line	6-8 lb fluorocarbon on spinning tackle.
Catches	Smallmouth, walleye, perch, crappie, largemouth. On Pine Lake's east wall it is the most reliable summer rig there is.

Build it

1. Tie a **Palomar knot** with the hook, but leave a very long tag end — 2 to 3 ft.
2. Pass that tag end **back down through the hook eye**, from the top. This is the step everyone forgets, and it is what makes the hook stand out from the line at right angles with the point up.
3. Attach the **weight** to the bottom of the tag with a simple overhand loop, or crimp it into the weight's line clip so it pulls free on a snag instead of costing you the rig.
4. Nose-hook the plastic through the very tip so it hangs horizontally and free.

Fish it

Drop straight down	This is primarily a vertical rig. Get over the fish and lower it.
Feel the weight land	Once it is down, take up slack until the line is just tight to the weight, and then stop reeling.
Shake, do not lift	Shake the rod tip. The weight never moves; only the bait quivers. That is the entire presentation, and you can do it in one spot for a minute at a time.
The bite	Often just added weight, or the line moving sideways. Reel down and sweep — no snap, small hook.
Where	Pine spots 3 (the east wall) and 4 (down the sides of the bar), 25-40 ft. North spots 3 and 4 .

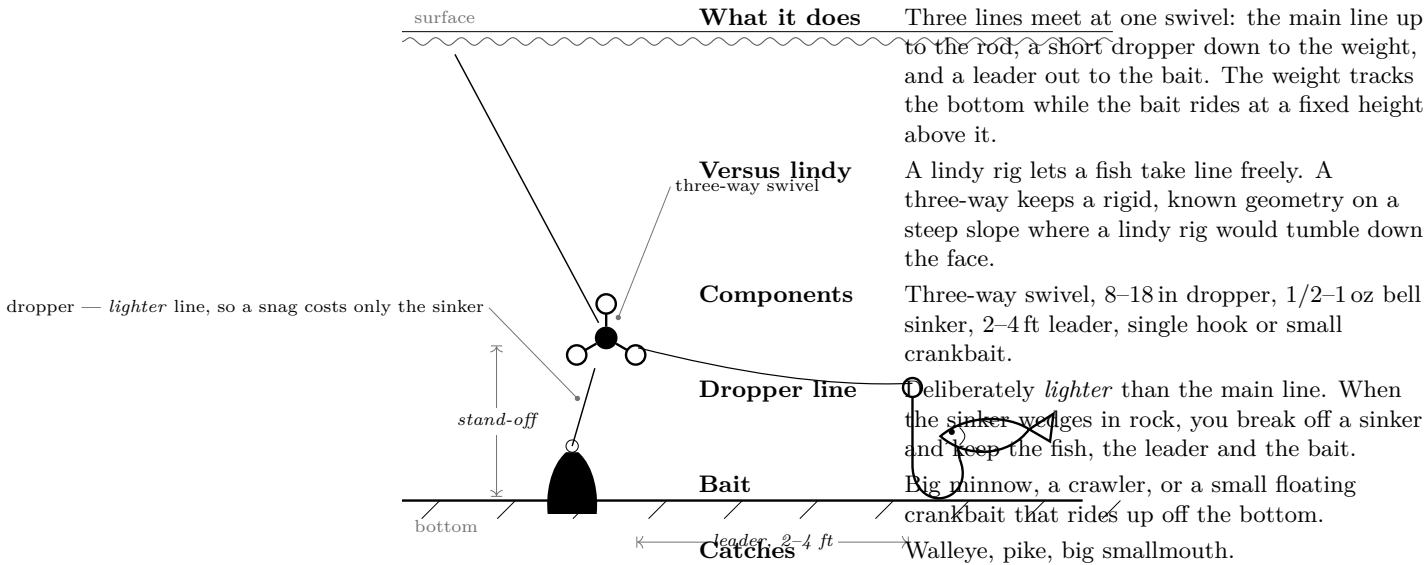
When to use it
August on Pine Lake, when the fish are deep, the sun is high and nothing is chasing. It is also the best rig in the guide for fishing a spot you can see on electronics: put it on their nose and leave it there.

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Three-Way Rig

Also called a wolf river rig

Hold a precise depth on a steep face where nothing else will



Build it

1. Tie the **main line** to the top eye of the three-way swivel.
2. Tie a short **dropper** of lighter line to the bottom eye, and the **sinker** to its end. Make the dropper as long as you want the bait to ride above the bottom.
3. Tie the **leader** to the third eye, then the hook or lure to the leader.

Fish it

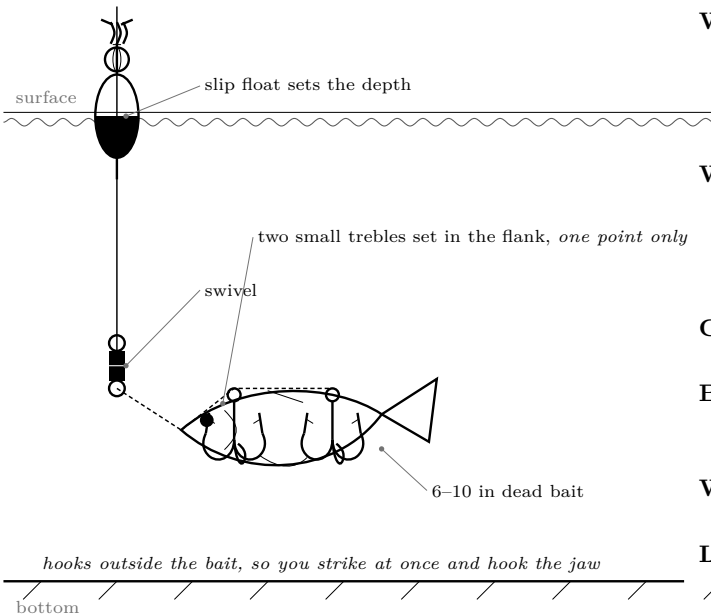
Troll or drift slowly	Move at a walking pace with the sinker just ticking bottom. The rig is designed to be moving.
Vertical line	Keep the line close to straight down. Let line out until you touch bottom, then take up a few inches. Re-check constantly on a slope — that is the whole point of the rig.
Feel for the change	You are following a contour. When the sinker stops touching, you have moved deep; when it drags hard, you have moved shallow. Steer to keep contact.
Set	A steady sweep. The fish usually hooks itself against the moving boat.
Where	Pine spot 3 — the east wall is the exact situation this rig was invented for — and the steep side of the bar at 4 . North spot 3 .

When to use it
On a drop too steep to fish any other way. If you keep losing bottom contact and then plowing, alternately, on a sharp break, this is the rig. It also lets you fish a floating crankbait a fixed 18 inches off the rocks, which is deadly on fall walleye.

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Quick-Strike Rig

Fish a big dead bait for pike and hook the fish, not its stomach



What it does	Two small treble hooks set into the flank of a large dead bait, on a wire trace. Because the hooks are on the <i>outside</i> of the bait, you strike immediately instead of waiting for the pike to swallow.
Why it matters	The old method — a single hook inside a bait, and a long wait — gut-hooks pike and kills fish you meant to release. A quick-strike rig hooks them in the jaw. This is the humane way to do it, and it is also more effective.
Components	Wire trace with two size 6–8 trebles, barrel swivel, slip float and stop, large dead bait.
Bait	A dead sucker, smelt or large shiner, 6–10 in. Dead bait works: pike scavenge readily, especially in cold water.
Wire	Not optional. Pike teeth cut monofilament instantly.
Line	20 lb braid or 15 lb mono; a rod with backbone.

Build and bait it

1. Rig the **slip float** on the main line — stop knot, bead, float — exactly as on the *see the slip bobber sheet* sheet. Set the depth so the bait hangs just above the weed tops.
2. Tie the main line to a **barrel swivel**, and the swivel to the **wire trace**.
3. Set the **rear treble** into the bait's flank near the tail, one point only, barely under the skin.
4. Set the **front treble** near the head, again one point only. The bait should hang naturally, not bent.

Fish it

Strike early	When the float goes down, count to five , reel until tight, and sweep hard. Do not give it a minute. Do not give it thirty seconds. The whole design assumes an early strike.
Tackle at hand	Long-nose pliers, side cutters and jaw spreaders in the boat before you cast, not after you hook one.
Cut, do not dig	If a hook is awkward, cut the treble with side cutters and back the pieces out. A cheap hook is worth less than the fish.
Where	Pine spots 1 and 9 in April and again in October; the deep weed edge at 5 in summer. North spots 2 , 5 and 6 .
Ice	The same rig on a tip-up is the standard big-pike presentation, <i>see the tip-up sheet</i> .

HANDLE PIKE PROPERLY

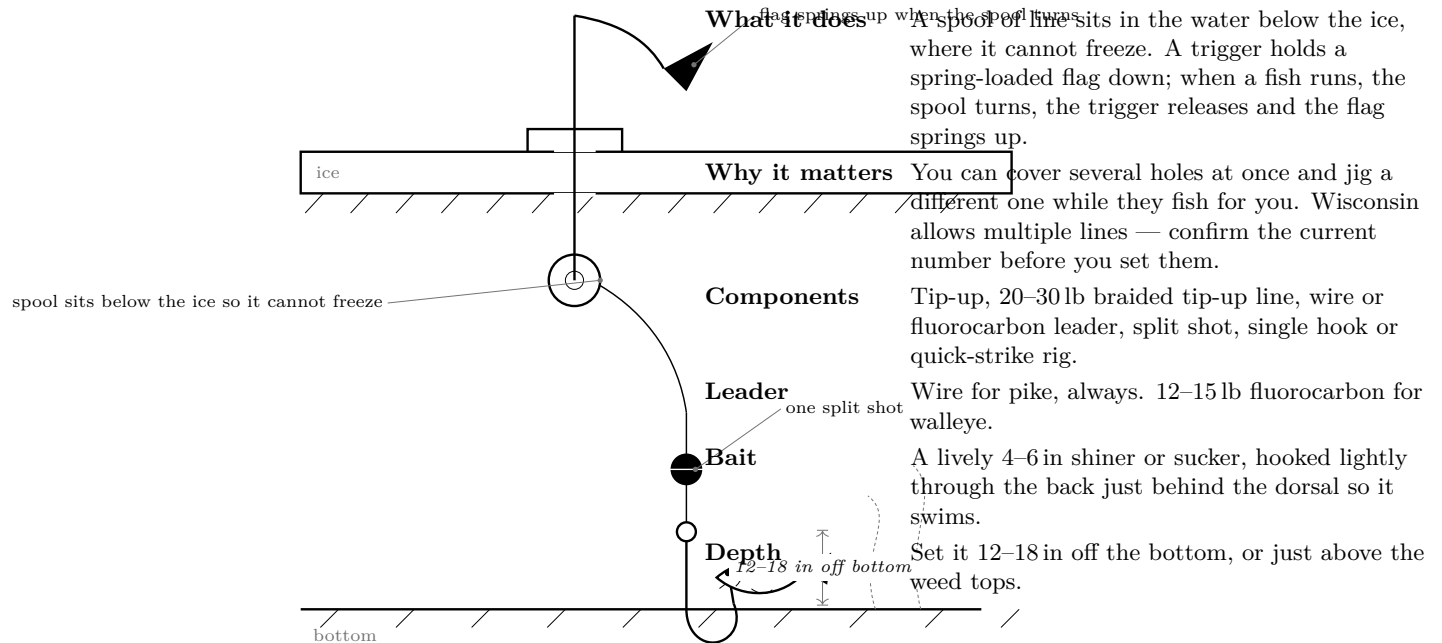
Backward-facing teeth, and a fish strong enough to thrash while you work. Jaw spreaders and long pliers every time; fingers never inside the mouth or under the gill plate. Pike over 70 °F water are fragile — unhook in the net, in the water, and release quickly. See the **Northern Pike** sheet.

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Tip-Up

Winter pike and walleye

Fish live bait under the ice while you fish somewhere else



Set it

1. Drill the hole and clear the slush completely, or the flag will freeze down and never trip.
2. Drop the baited rig until it touches bottom, then reel up 12–18 in and mark that line depth with a rubber band or a clip so you can reset the same depth all day.
3. Set the trigger with the flag bent under it. Test it once by hand — a trigger set too tight will not release for a fish.
4. Bank snow around the base of the tip-up to keep the hole from refreezing.

When the flag goes

Walk, do not run	Footsteps on clear ice carry. Approach quietly, especially in shallow water.
Watch the spool	If it is still turning, the fish is moving. Let it run. If it has stopped, wait until it starts again — that is the fish turning the bait.
Set by hand	Pick the line up off the spool, take up slack until you feel the fish, and pull firmly hand over hand. There is no rod to absorb a snap, so a smooth strong pull is correct.
Bring it up hand over hand	Lay line on the ice away from the hole so it cannot tangle back down.
Where	Pine spots 1 , 6 and 9 over weed edges in 8–15 ft; North spots 1 and 5 . Pike season closes 7 March — check the current dates.

ICE IS NEVER GUARANTEED

No ice is safe ice. Check thickness yourself as you go rather than trusting somebody else's report; four inches of clear ice is a common minimum for one person on foot, and more for a group. Springs, inlets, outlets and current thin the ice unpredictably — on North Lake the river inflow and outflow at spots **2** and **6** are exactly the places to stay off. Carry ice picks around your neck, take a rope, and do not go out alone.

IV Reference

Why fish are where they are, what to carry, when to go, the four knots that cover everything here, how to put a fish back so it lives, and how to take somebody out for the first time.

Reading Water

*The sheet that makes the other sheets
portable*

Why fish are where they are, so you can find them on any lake

Every numbered spot in this guide was chosen by the same reasoning, and once you can do that reasoning yourself you no longer need the numbers. Fish are not distributed evenly. They stack up wherever two things meet.

The one idea: fish live on edges

What an edge is	Any place where the water changes — shallow to deep, weed to open, hard bottom to soft, warm to cold, bright to shaded, current to still. An edge gives a predator cover on one side and hunting ground on the other, and it concentrates the food chain from the bottom up.
The best spots have two	A weed edge is good. A weed edge on a point is better. A weed edge on a point next to a fast drop into deep water is where everything in the lake eventually shows up. Pine Lake's mid-lake bar is four edges stacked in one place, which is why it is spot 4.
The featureless middle	A flat, uniform bottom in open water holds almost nothing. If you cannot name the edge you are fishing, you are probably not fishing anything.

The edges worth finding, in order

Edge	Why fish use it	On these lakes
Break (drop-off)	A fish can move between shallow feeding and deep safety without crossing open water. The steeper the break, the less distance that move costs, so steep breaks hold fish through more of the day.	Pine 3 (east wall), 8; North 3, 7
Weed edge	The outside line where weed growth stops for lack of light. Bait hides inside it, predators patrol outside it. In clear water it is deep; in stained water it is shallow.	Pine 5 at 12–18 ft; North 1 at 6–10 ft
Point	A finger of shallow ground reaching into deep water. It intercepts fish moving along a shoreline and it catches wind. Fish the <i>end</i> , not the sides.	Pine 2, 8; North 3
Bar or hump	Shallow structure isolated in deep water. The best of all, because it is the only cover for a long way and fish have to commit to it.	Pine 4; North 4
Inside turn	A notch where the depth line bends back toward shore. Fish moving along a break funnel into it.	Pine 2, 7; North 2
Neck or narrows	Anywhere a lake pinches. Everything that moves between two areas passes through, and current keeps the bottom clean.	North 5
Inlet / outlet	Moving water: different temperature, oxygen, and a constant delivery of food. First place to look in early spring and late fall.	Pine 9; North 2, 6
Wind-blown shore	Wind pushes plankton against a bank, then baitfish, then predators. Uncomfortable to fish, which is exactly why it is uncrowded.	Whichever side the wind is on
Shade line	The edge of a dock, an overhanging tree, a weed mat. A fish in shade sees out; you cannot see in. Midday, high sun.	Pine 6, 7; North 1

The invisible edge: the thermocline

What happens	By early summer a deep lake settles into three layers: a warm mixed layer on top, a thin band where temperature falls sharply — the thermocline — and cold, dense water below.
Why it matters	The layers stop mixing. Below the thermocline, oxygen is no longer being replenished. In most lakes that makes the deep water uninhabitable by midsummer, so <i>every fish in the lake</i> is squeezed into the water above it.
Pine Lake is the exception	It is deep and clean enough to keep oxygen in the cold layer, which is why it holds cisco. That means predators here have somewhere to go that most lakes do not — and in July and August they go there. <i>see the Cisco sheet</i>
How to find it	On sonar it is often a faint horizontal band of clutter. Or lower a thermometer: where the reading drops several degrees in a couple of feet, that is it. Typically 15–25 ft in this part of Wisconsin.
Turnover	In autumn the surface cools until the layers have the same density and the whole lake mixes. For a week or two the water looks cloudy and the fishing is genuinely poor. Then it is the best month of the year.

A method for a lake you have never seen

1. Look at a contour map *before* you launch and mark every point, bar, inside turn and narrows. That is your list of candidate spots and it costs nothing.
2. On the water, find the weed line first. It tells you how far light penetrates, which tells you how deep everything else will be.
3. Start shallow and early. Work out and down as the sun climbs.
4. Fish an edge, not an area. Keep the boat on one depth and follow it.
5. When you catch one, stop and note the depth, the bottom, and the edge. Then find the same combination somewhere else on the lake — fish are creatures of pattern, and the pattern repeats.

The point of the numbered spots

The nine spots on Pine Lake and the seven on North Lake are not secrets; they are worked examples. Each one is a named edge, and the lake sheets say which edge and why. Learn the reasoning and you can walk up to any lake in the county and produce your own list before you get the boat wet.

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Lures & Baits

Pine Lake & North Lake

What to carry, and what each thing is actually for

A tackle box fills up with things that catch fishermen. This sheet is the short list that catches fish on these two lakes, with the reason each item exists. Buy depth and colour variety in the few categories that matter, not one of everything.

Hard baits

Lure	Size	What it is for and how to work it	Target
Inline spinner	1/8–1/4 oz	Steady retrieve, blade turning. The simplest lure that works. Excellent for a beginner because a constant speed is all it needs.	Panfish, bass, pike
Spinnerbait	3/8–3/4 oz	Safety-pin wire arm makes it near-weedless. Slow-roll it over and through weed tops. The pike lure on North Lake.	Pike, largemouth
Squarebill crankbait	2–2.5 in	Dives 3–6 ft and deflects off cover. Bump it into weeds and rock; the strike comes as it ricochets.	Largemouth, smallmouth
Deep crankbait	2.5–3 in	Dives 12–20 ft. Trolled or cast along a break. Fall walleye.	Walleye, pike
Suspending jerkbait	4–5 in	Twitch, twitch, <i>pause</i> . The pause is the presentation — count to five in cold water.	Smallmouth, walleye, pike
Casting spoon	1/2–1 oz	Flutters on the fall. Cast, count down, retrieve in sweeps. Also the standard ice jigging spoon.	Pike, walleye
Walking topwater	4 in	Rod-tip cadence makes it swing side to side. First and last light only.	Largemouth
Popper	2–3 in	Chug, pause, chug. Over shallow weed on calm summer mornings.	Largemouth, big bluegill

Soft plastics and jigs

Item	Size	What it is for	Rig it on
Stick worm	5 in	The single most productive bass bait on Pine Lake. Buy these before anything else.	see the <i>wacky rig</i> sheet, see the <i>Texas rig</i> sheet
Ribbon-tail worm	7 in	More action on the fall than a stick worm; better in stained water.	see the <i>Texas rig</i> sheet, see the <i>Carolina rig</i> sheet
Tube	3–4 in	Spirals and puffs like a fleeing crayfish. The best smallmouth bait there is.	Tube jig head
Craw / creature	3–4 in	Bulk and appendages. Punching weed and flipping wood.	see the <i>Texas rig</i> sheet
Minnow-shaped plastic	3–4 in	Slim profile that hangs horizontally.	see the <i>drop-shot</i> sheet
Round jig head	1/16–3/8 oz	Weight and hook in one. Carry the whole range — depth dictates weight.	see the <i>jig-and-minnow</i> sheet
Panfish jig	1/32–1/16 oz	Tiny hair or plastic jig under a float or on its own.	see the <i>slip bobber</i> sheet
Bass jig & trailer	3/8–1/2 oz	Weedguard and a skirt. Slow, deliberate, big-fish bait around wood and weed edges.	Direct tie

Live bait

Bait	When and why	Hook it
Nightcrawler	The universal bait. Half a crawler out-fishes a whole one for panfish, because a small mouth cannot get the whole thing.	Thread on, leave a short tail moving
Leech	The best walleye bait from late May through summer. Swims with a ribbon motion nothing imitates.	Once through the sucker end
Fathead minnow	Cold water: ice-out through May, and October on. Hardy in the bucket.	Up through both lips
Golden shiner	Bigger, flashier, more fragile. Pike and walleye.	Through the back, behind the dorsal
Sucker (dead, 6–10 in)	Winter and cold-water pike. Dead bait works — pike scavenge.	see the <i>quick-strike rig sheet</i>
Waxworm / spike	Ice fishing and tight-lipped summer panfish.	One or two on a tiny jig
Crayfish	The premium smallmouth bait on Pine Lake’s gravel.	Plain hook through the tail, one split shot

Colour, in one paragraph

Pine Lake is very clear: natural and translucent colours — green pumpkin, watermelon, smoke, silver, real crayfish brown. North Lake is stained: brighter and more solid — chartreuse, white, black, gold, firetiger. In both lakes, black or dark purple is the most visible silhouette in low light and at night. If you only ever carry three soft-plastic colours, carry green pumpkin, black, and white.

Do not move live bait between waters. Wisconsin has strict rules on transporting live fish and water to prevent spreading invasive species and disease. Drain everything, and dispose of unused bait in the trash rather than the lake. Confirm the current bait rules with the DNR — they are enforced.

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Seasonal Calendar

*Pine Lake & North Lake — the whole year
on one sheet*

Which fish, which month, which depth, which spot

Fish do not follow the calendar; they follow water temperature, and the calendar is only a rough proxy for it. A cold spring pushes everything two weeks late. Use the temperature column, not the month, whenever you can measure it.

The year by species

Species	Activity by month	Peak periods and where
Largemouth bass	Activity levels: Jan (low), Feb (low), Mar (low), Apr (medium), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (medium-high), Oct (medium-high), Nov (medium), Dec (low).	May–Jun shallow, pre-spawn and spawn: Pine 6, 7; North 1, 7. Sep–Oct feeding hard on the weed edge: Pine 5; North 1.
Smallmouth bass	Activity levels: Jan (low), Feb (low), Mar (low), Apr (medium), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (medium-high), Dec (low).	May–Jun on gravel: Pine 2, 4. Oct the best of the year: Pine 3, 4; North 4.
Walleye	Activity levels: Jan (medium), Feb (medium), Mar (medium), Apr (medium-high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (medium-high), Dec (medium).	Oct–Nov on the breaks: Pine 3, 4, 8; North 3, 4. Dawn and dusk all year.
Northern pike	Activity levels: Jan (high), Feb (high), Mar (high), Apr (high), May (medium-high), Jun (medium-high), Jul (medium), Aug (medium), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (high), Dec (medium-high).	Apr post-spawn in the shallows and Oct–Nov feeding up: Pine 1, 9; North 2, 6.
Bluegill	Activity levels: Jan (high), Feb (high), Mar (medium), Apr (medium-high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (medium-high), Nov (medium), Dec (medium-high).	Late May–Jun on the beds: Pine 6; North 1. Deep weed edge after.
Pumpkinseed	Activity levels: Jan (medium), Feb (medium), Mar (medium), Apr (medium-high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (medium-high), Dec (medium-high).	Same beds as bluegill, slightly shallower and tighter to cover.
Black crappie	Activity levels: Jan (high), Feb (high), Mar (medium), Apr (high), May (high), Jun (medium-high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (medium-high), Dec (high).	May near brush and Jan through the ice. Dusk always.
Yellow perch	Activity levels: Jan (high), Feb (high), Mar (high), Apr (high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (high), Aug (high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (high), Dec (high).	Dec–Feb the best perch fishing of the year, on the 15–30 ft flats. Daylight only.
Rock bass	Activity levels: Jan (medium), Feb (medium), Mar (medium), Apr (medium-high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (high), Aug (high), Sep (high), Oct (medium-high), Nov (medium-high), Dec (medium-high).	Jun–Aug on any rock. The reliable summer fish for a child.
Cisco	Activity levels: Jan (high), Feb (medium), Mar (low), Apr (low), May (low), Jun (low), Jul (low), Aug (low), Sep (low), Oct (medium), Nov (high), Dec (high).	Nov–Dec spawning shallow; through the ice in Jan . Pine Lake only.

The year by water temperature

Water	Roughly	What is happening, and what to do
32–40 °F	Dec–Mar	Ice. Panfish in the bays, perch on the flats, pike on tip-ups over weed edges. Everything moves slowly; small baits, long pauses.
40–45 °F	Late Mar–Apr	Ice-out. Pike spawn in flooded shallows — the first fish to go. Walleye follow onto rock. Fish the north and west shorelines, which warm first.
45–55 °F	Apr–early May	Walleye spawn and then feed. Crappie push into bays. Slow presentations, live bait, dark bottoms that hold heat.
55–65 °F	May–early Jun	Bass spawn , largemouth first and smallmouth just after. Bass season opens the first Saturday in May. The single best window of the year for numbers of fish, shallow.
65–72 °F	Jun	Panfish spawn on colonial beds. Everything is shallow and visible. This is the month to take children.
72–80 °F	Jul–Aug	The lake stratifies. Fish split: some hold the deep weed edge, some go to the hard structure, and on Pine some suspend over the basin following cisco. Fish early, late, and deep.
72–60 °F	Sep	Turnover. The surface cools, the layers mix, and for one to two weeks the fishing is genuinely poor and the water may look cloudy. Wait it out.
60–45 °F	Oct–Nov	The best fishing of the year. Big fish feed heavily and move onto structure. Larger baits, and do not be afraid to fish the middle of the day.
45–33 °F	Nov–Dec	Deep and slow. Then first ice, which is often excellent — and the most dangerous ice of the season.

Times of day

Dawn	The most reliable hour on both lakes for almost everything. Non-negotiable in July and August.	
Midday	Perch and rock bass feed; most predators do not. Bright calm midday is when finesse presentations earn their keep, <i>see the wacky rig sheet</i> and <i>see the drop-shot sheet</i> .	
Dusk	The best hour for walleye and crappie. Be on the spot before the light goes rather than arriving with it.	
Night	Walleye and big pike keep feeding; panfish shut down entirely.	
Weather	A falling barometer ahead of a front turns fish on hard. The day after a cold front passes is the worst day of any week — go deeper, slow down, and downsize.	
Wind	Wind on a point or a bar concentrates plankton, then baitfish, then predators. Fish the windy shore, not the comfortable one.	

Season dates change every year. On these waters in 2026–27, gamefish open 2 May and bass, walleye and pike close 7 March; musky is open water only through 31 December; panfish are open all year. Confirm with the Wisconsin DNR before every trip.

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Knots

Learn these four and stop there

Four knots will cover everything in this guide

Every knot weakens the line it is tied in; a good knot simply weakens it less. Two habits matter more than which knot you choose: **wet it before you pull it tight**, because friction burns and permanently weakens monofilament, and **seat it slowly with steady pressure**, then look at it. A knot with a crossed wrap is a knot that will fail on the best fish of the day.

The four

Knot	Use it for	How to tie it
Improved clinch	Hook, swivel or lure to line. The everyday knot.	Pass the tag through the eye. Twist the tag around the standing line five to seven times. Pass the tag back through the small loop right at the eye, then <i>back through the large loop</i> you just created — that second pass is the “improved” part and it is what stops it slipping. Wet and pull the standing line slowly. Trim close.
Palomar	Braid to anything; the <i>see the drop-shot sheet</i> . Stronger than a clinch and harder to tie wrong.	Double about six inches of line and pass the doubled loop through the eye. Tie a loose overhand knot with the doubled line, leaving the hook hanging. Pass the loop completely <i>over</i> the hook. Wet, then pull both the standing line and the tag to seat it. Trim.
Uni (grinner)	Leader to hook; and tied twice, back to back, it joins two lines of different diameter.	Pass the tag through the eye and lay it back alongside the standing line to form a loop. Wrap the tag through that loop and around both strands five or six times. Wet and pull the tag to close the coils, then slide the whole knot down to the eye.
Double surgeon’s	Joining leader to main line quickly, including with cold hands.	Lay the two lines alongside each other, overlapping by six inches. Treating them as one, tie a simple overhand knot, then pass the same ends through a second time. Wet, and pull all four ends at once. Trim both tags.

Getting them right

Wet every knot	Saliva or water, every time, before the final pull. A dry-cinched mono knot can lose a third of its strength to friction heat and you will never see the damage.
Pull the right end	On a clinch and a Palomar, seat the knot by pulling the <i>standing line</i> steadily — not by yanking the tag.
Leave a short tag	About 1/8 inch. Cutting flush lets the tag pull back through under load; leaving half an inch collects weed.
Look at it	Coils should lie in a neat barrel with no crossovers. If it looks wrong it is wrong. Cut it off and tie it again — it takes twenty seconds.
Retie often	After every fish over a couple of pounds, after any snag, and after fishing rock. Run the last two feet of line between your fingers: if you feel roughness, cut it back and retie.
Braid is different	Braid is slippery. Use a Palomar, or add extra wraps to a uni. A standard clinch in braid will slip.

Two things that are not knots

Snap swivel	A fast way to change lures, and it lets a lure swing freely. But it is one more failure point and it is visible — so on Pine Lake’s clear water, tie direct.
Wire leader	Not optional for pike, <i>see the Northern Pike sheet</i> . Most are pre-made with a swivel and snap. If you tie your own, use a haywire twist rather than trying to knot single-strand wire.

Teaching these

Practise on rope or paracord first, at a size a child can see, before touching 6 lb monofilament on a windy dock. Learn the improved clinch until it can be tied without looking, then the Palomar. Those two alone will cover everything on every rig sheet in this guide.

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Handling & Release

Do this right and it costs you thirty seconds

A released fish that dies anyway was not released

Most fish you catch on these lakes go back — everything under 14 inches, every bass out of season, and anything you simply do not need. Whether those fish survive is decided almost entirely in the sixty seconds after they reach the boat, and almost all of it is under your control.

The rules, in order of how much they matter

- 1. Keep it in the water** Every second out of water is a second not breathing. Unhook a fish in the net, in the water, whenever you can. If you want a photograph, get the camera ready *first*, then lift.
- 2. Wet your hands** Dry hands, a dry towel and a dry deck strip the protective slime coat, and the raw patch underneath is where infection and fungus start. Wet hands, wet net, wet everything.
- 3. Support the weight** One hand under the belly on anything over a couple of pounds. Holding a heavy fish vertically by the jaw stretches and tears the joint and the organs behind it. A bass under about two pounds is fine held by the lower lip; above that, use two hands.
- 4. Never touch the gills** Gill filaments are exposed blood vessels. A fish bleeding from the gills is a fish that will die, whatever it looks like when it swims off. No fingers under the plate, ever.
- 5. Cut the line on a deep hook** If the hook is in the throat or gut, **do not dig for it**. Cut the line as close as you can and let the fish go. A left hook rusts out or is expelled; a torn oesophagus does not heal.
- 6. Revive it properly** Hold it upright, facing into any current, or move it gently *forward* through the water. Never sweep it back and forth — water runs the wrong way through the gills and it does harm rather than good. Let go when it kicks free on its own.

What makes it worse

Factor	What to do about it
Warm water	Above roughly 75 °F a fish recovers slowly and its oxygen demand is high. In July and August, keep handling times short, revive longer, and consider moving to a different lesson for the day if fish are clearly struggling. Pike are the most fragile of the lot in warm water.
Deep water	A fish pulled quickly from more than about 25–30 ft may suffer barotrauma: the swim bladder over-expands and it cannot swim down. Signs are bloating, bulging eyes, or a fish that floats on its side. If you are catching fish deep and intend to release them, fish shallower or keep what you catch.
Long fight	Playing a fish to complete exhaustion on light line is hard on it. Use tackle heavy enough to land the fish quickly.
Treble hooks	Three times the chance of a bad hookset. Crush the barbs, or replace a set of trebles with single hooks on baits you use around fish you will release.
Handling a pike	Backward-facing teeth and a fish strong enough to thrash. Jaw spreaders and long pliers, every time. <i>see the Northern Pike sheet</i>

Keep a fish properly, too

- | | |
|---------------------------------|--|
| Decide early | Kill it or release it in the first minute. A fish kept on a stringer for two hours and then released is worse off than one killed immediately, and it is worse eating than one iced immediately. |
| Ice it | A cooler with ice, not a bucket of lake water. Quality falls fast in a warm bucket, and this is the single biggest difference between panfish that taste good and panfish that do not. |
| Take a meal, not a limit | Especially on bluegill beds in June, where the big males you are catching are the ones guarding the nests. <i>see the Bluegill sheet</i> |
| Know the rules | Length and bag limits are per water body and change every year. Measure before you decide. <i>see the Seasonal Calendar sheet</i> |

Clean, drain, dry. Before you leave a landing: remove all weed and mud, drain the livewell, bilge and bait bucket, and never move live fish or lake water to another water body. Wisconsin enforces this. Invasive species and fish disease move on trailers, and once they are in a lake like Pine they do not come back out.

Teaching it

This is the sheet to work through before the first trip, not after the first fish. A child who is taught to wet their hands and keep the fish in the net will do it for the rest of their life without thinking about it; one who learns it after dropping a bass on a hot dock has already learnt the other thing.

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A First Trip

Plan for catching, not for fishing

How to take somebody fishing who has never been

The failure mode of a first trip is always the same: an adult who wants to catch a good fish takes a beginner to a place where good fish live, and the beginner spends four hours not catching anything and concludes that fishing is boring. They are right. Plan the opposite trip.

The plan

Target bluegill	Not bass, not walleye, not "whatever bites". In June a bluegill bed will produce a fish every few minutes, and constant action is the entire point. <i>see the Bluegill sheet</i>
Go in June	Late May through June, when panfish are on the beds in 1–4 ft of water and you can see them. Pine Lake spot 6 ; North Lake spot 1 .
Go in the evening	Two hours before dark, not eight in the morning. Warmer, calmer, better bite, and a natural end to the trip.
Keep it short	Ninety minutes. Leave while it is still fun. The trip should end because you decided to end it, not because somebody has stopped enjoying it.
One rod each	A short spinning rod, 4lb line, a fixed bobber a couple of feet above a size 8 hook, half a worm. <i>see the slip bobber sheet</i> — but use a fixed float, not a slip float, for the first trip.
Pinch the barbs	Flatten every barb with pliers. You will lose a few fish and you will save yourself the one memory that ends the hobby: a barbed hook in a finger, an hour from the car.

What to bring

- Rod, already rigged, at home
- A spare rod, also already rigged
- Worms, more than you think
- Long-nose pliers
- Nail clippers for line
- Landing net
- Wet towel
- Life jackets that fit *them*
- Sunscreen and a hat
- Bug spray
- Snacks and water — more than the fishing gear, honestly
- Something to keep fish in, if keeping
- A first-aid kit with tweezers

The first hour, in order

1. **Rig everything at home.** Not at the water, not in the wind, not while somebody is waiting. Arrive ready to cast.
2. **Life jackets on before the boat.** No discussion, and the adult wears one too — they will do what you do, not what you say.
3. **Five minutes on casting, on grass, before you leave.** A weight and no hook. Underhand flip, not overhead. It removes the largest source of frustration on the water.
4. **Anchor on the bed and stay put.** Do not run around looking for better. Better is worse.
5. **Let them do everything they can.** Bait the hook badly, cast badly, reel too fast. Your job is to untangle things and say very little.
6. **Show them the first fish properly.** Wet hands, look at the gill flap, name it, count the spines, let them hold it, put it back. *see the **Handling & Release sheet***
7. **Leave on a fish.** When the bite is still good and they are still laughing, that is the moment to go.

Things that go wrong, and the fix

Problem	Fix
Tangles	Inevitable. Carry the pre-rigged spare rod, hand it over, and untangle the first one later. Do not make a child stand and watch you pick at a bird's nest for ten minutes.
Nothing biting	You are in the wrong spot or too deep. Move shallower, go smaller, use less bait. Half a worm out-fishes a whole one for panfish every time.
Bored	The bite has slowed. Change activity rather than persisting: look at what is in the water, catch a crayfish under a rock, throw the cast net, go home. Fishing is not the only good thing about being at a lake.
Hook in a finger	This is why the barbs are pinched. Back it out the way it went in, clean it, plaster on it, carry on. With a barb still on, cut the line and see a doctor.
Frightened of the fish	Normal. Hold it yourself first, let them touch it while you hold it, and do not push. They will pick one up within a couple of trips.

The measure of success

Not the size of the fish, and not how many. The measure is whether they ask to go again. Everything on this sheet is arranged to make that answer yes.

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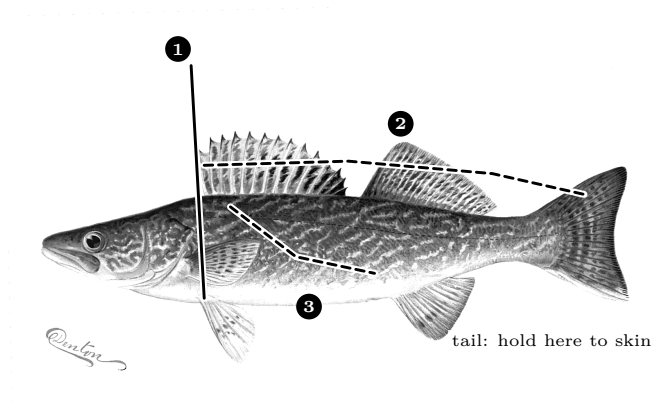
V Cooking

How good each fish is to eat, how to fillet it — with the cuts drawn on the same plate you identified it from — which bones to watch for, and three ways to cook it.

Cooking Walleye

Sander vitreus — in the kitchen

The best-eating fish in either lake, and the cheeks nobody takes



The Pike Perch or Wall-Eyed Pike — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	The reason people drive to Wisconsin. Firm, white, large-flaked, and so mild that the fish tastes of what you cook it in.
Texture	Dense and moist, holds together in a pan where a bluegill falls apart. Forgiving of slight overcooking.
Oil	Low. Keeps poorly frozen past about four months — the flavour goes flat rather than fishy.
Best size	18–22 in, which is also the legal window here. A very large walleye is coarser and worth releasing anyway.
Yield	About 35% of whole weight as skinless fillet. A 20 in fish gives two fillets around 6 oz each — one generous portion.
Skin	Always remove it. Walleye skin is tough and does not crisp.

Filleting

1. **Cut down behind the gill plate**, angling slightly toward the head, until you feel the backbone. Do not cut through it.
2. **Turn the blade flat** and run it along the top of the backbone from head to tail, letting the spine guide the knife. One long stroke beats twenty short ones. Leave the fillet attached at the tail as a handle.
3. **Lift the fillet and slice the rib cage out** in a shallow arc, taking as little meat as you can. Or skip this and pull the rib bones with pliers after skinning.
4. **Skin it:** lay the fillet skin-side down, hold the tail, and run the knife between skin and flesh at a slight downward angle, sawing gently while pulling the skin.
5. **Take the cheeks.** Two coin-sized nuggets of the best meat on the fish, in the hollow behind and below the eye. Cut a semicircle through the skin, pop the meat out with the knife tip, peel the skin off. Most people throw these away. Do not be most people.
6. Rinse in cold water, pat dry, and get it on ice or in the pan.

Bones

Rib cage	The only bones to deal with, and step 3 removes them.
No Y-bones	Unlike pike, a walleye fillet is genuinely boneless once the ribs are out. <i>see the Cooking Northern Pike sheet</i>
Run a finger	Along the fillet before cooking, tip to tail, feeling for anything sharp. Thirty seconds now saves a bad mouthful later.

Three ways to cook it

Method	How
Pan-fried	The standard, and the best. Dry the fillet hard. Dredge in seasoned flour, or beaten egg then cracker crumbs. Medium-high heat, butter and a little oil so the butter does not burn. Three minutes a side for a half-inch fillet. Lemon. Nothing else.
Beer-battered	For a fish fry. Flour, cornstarch, baking powder, cold beer, whisked to thin-cream consistency. 375 °F oil, three to four minutes to golden. Drain on a rack, never on paper — paper steams the crust off.
Baked whole fillets	For a bigger batch. 400 °F, butter, lemon slices, paprika, ten to twelve minutes. Done when it flakes at a gentle push and the flesh has just turned opaque.

The one rule
Walleye is a mild fish and every minute past done makes it worse. Pull it when the centre has <i>just</i> gone from glassy to opaque — it carries on cooking off the heat. Overcooked walleye is dry and ordinary, which is a waste of the best fish in the lake.

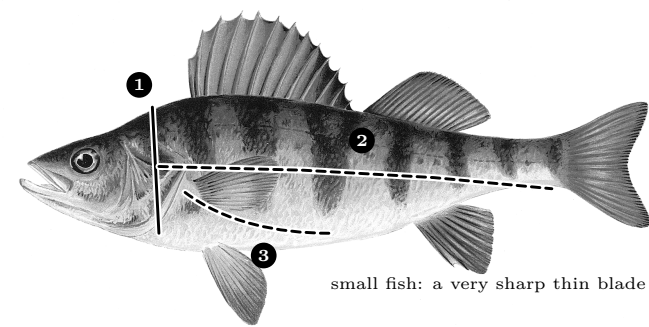
Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For walleye, pike, bass and catfish: **one serving per month** for women under 50 and children under 15; **one serving per week** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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Cooking Yellow Perch

Pound for pound the finest eating in fresh water

Perca flavescens — in the kitchen



Yellow or Barred Perch — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	The best-eating fish in either lake, and arguably in fresh water. Sweeter and firmer than walleye, in a smaller package.
Texture	Firm, fine-grained, faintly sweet. Never mushy.
Best size	9 in and up makes filleting worth the effort. Below that, pan-dress instead.
Yield	Low — about 25%, and a 9 in perch gives two fillets of barely 1.5 oz. This is a fish you need a dozen of.
Ice fishing	Winter perch out of 34 °F water are the best of all. see the <i>Seasonal Calendar sheet</i>
Scales	Fine and very well attached. Filleting and skinning beats scaling every time.

Filleting a small fish

1. Use a **thin, very sharp, flexible blade**. A thick knife on a 9 in perch wastes half the fish.
2. **Cut behind the gill plate** down to the backbone.
3. **Run the blade along the backbone** to the tail in one stroke. On a fish this small, resist sawing.
4. **Skin it** from the tail, and take the ribs with the skin if you can — on perch it is often faster to cut the rib section away entirely and accept the small loss.
5. **Or pan-dress instead:** scale, gut, cut the head off behind the gills, and cook it whole on the bone. Below about 9 in this gives you more food than filleting does.

Bones and what to watch for

Spiny dorsal	The first dorsal fin is genuinely sharp and so are the gill covers. Handle a live perch from the head-on direction, or with a cloth.
Rib cage	Small and fine. Cut it out or pull it with pliers.
Nothing else	No Y-bones, no pin bones. A perch fillet is clean.
Pan-dressed	Eaten off the bone, the frame lifts out in one piece after cooking.

Cooking it

Method	How
Pan-fried	The only method that really matters. Egg wash, then cracker crumbs or fine cornmeal. Butter, medium-high, ninety seconds a side. They are small — they cook fast.
Perch fry	The Friday institution. Beer batter, 375 °F, two to three minutes. Serve with rye bread, coleslaw and a lemon wedge, which is how it is done here.
Whole and crisp	Pan-dressed fish, scored, dusted in seasoned flour, shallow-fried until the fins go crisp. Eat the fins. They are the best part and nobody believes it until they try.

Worth the work
Perch are small and cleaning a dozen takes a while, which is exactly why so few people bother and why the ones who do eat better than everybody else. Set up an assembly line: one person fillets, one skins, one rinses and ices. Twenty

minutes for a family meal of the best fish in the county.

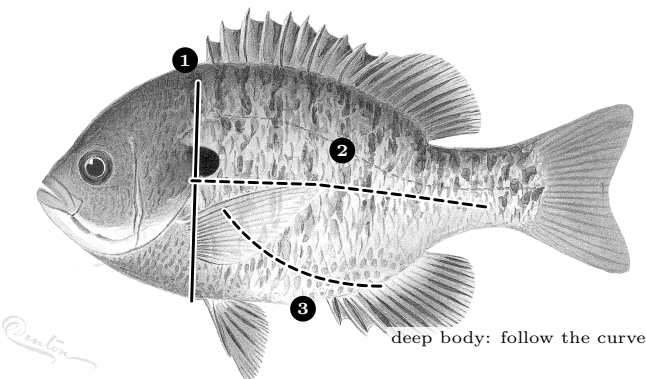
Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For bluegill, crappie, yellow perch, sunfish, rock bass and bullhead: **one serving per week** for women under 50 and children under 15; **unrestricted** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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Cooking Bluegill

Lepomis macrochirus — in the kitchen

The fish most people learn to clean on



Blue Gill Sun Fish — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Sweet, delicate and white. Slightly softer than perch but every bit as good, and there are usually a lot more of them.
Texture	Fine and tender. It will fall apart if you handle it roughly in the pan — that is the only difficulty.
Best size	8 in and up to fillet. Below that, pan-dress. A 9 in bluegill is a trophy and a superb meal.
Yield	Poor — about 22%. The deep body shape means a lot of fish becomes a little fillet. Budget three or four fish per person.
Ethics	June bed fish are the easiest to catch and the ones the population needs. Take a meal, not a cooler. <i>see the Bluegill sheet</i>
Freezing	Freeze in a block of water rather than dry — delicate flesh burns quickly in a freezer.

Filleting a deep-bodied fish

1. **Cut behind the gill plate**, following the curve of the gill cover down and around, to the backbone.
2. **Run the blade along the backbone** to the tail. On a deep-bodied fish the backbone sits high — roughly halfway up — so aim higher than feels right.
3. **Take the ribs** with a shallow arc, or cut the whole belly section away.
4. **Skin it** from the tail end. Bluegill skin releases easily.
5. **Or pan-dress:** scale it with the back of a knife against the grain, gut it, cut the head off behind the gills, trim the fins. Cook whole. For fish under about 8 in this is both faster and gives more food.

Bones and what to watch for

Spines	The dorsal spines are sharp. Trim the whole spiny dorsal off first with kitchen shears — it makes the rest safer and quicker.
Rib cage	Fine and easy to lift out.
No pin bones	A bluegill fillet is clean once the ribs are out.
Pan-dressed	The whole skeleton lifts out in one piece after cooking. Teach a child to do this and they will eat fish for life.

Cooking it

Method	How
Cornmeal-fried	Buttermilk, then fine cornmeal with salt and cayenne. Hot oil, two minutes a side. The classic and still the best.
Whole and crisp	Pan-dressed, scored twice on each side, floured, shallow-fried until crisp. Eat everything except the spine.
Bluegill cakes	For a big catch of small fish. Poach the fillets, flake, bind with egg, breadcrumbs, spring onion and mustard. Fry as patties. This is what to do with a hundred small ones.

The teaching fish

Bluegill is the right fish to learn knife work on: there are lots of them, they are cheap to ruin, and the anatomy is simple and obvious. Let a teenager fillet six badly before you correct anything. The seventh will be fine, and they will have learnt more than any amount of watching.

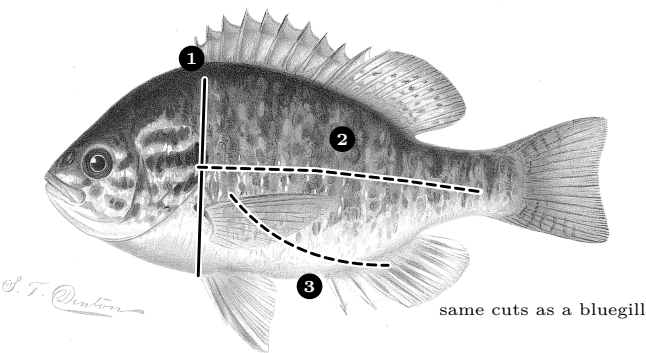
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Cooking Pumpkinseed

Lepomis gibbosus — in the kitchen

Treat it exactly as a bluegill, because it is one for these purposes



Sunfish (*Eupomotis gibbosus*) — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Indistinguishable from bluegill on the plate — sweet, white, delicate.
Size	Usually smaller than the bluegill it shares a bed with, which is the only practical difference. A 7 in pumpkinseed is a good one.
Yield	About 20%. Below 7 in, pan-dress rather than fillet.
Mixed catch	You will almost always be cleaning these alongside bluegill. There is no reason to separate them.
Hybrids	Bluegill and pumpkinseed interbreed freely. If a fish fits neither description, it eats the same either way.
Freezing	In water, not dry. Delicate flesh burns fast.

Filleting or pan-dressing

1. **Shear off the spiny dorsal** with kitchen scissors before anything else. It makes the fish safe to hold.
2. **Cut behind the gill plate**, following the gill cover’s curve, down to the backbone.
3. **Run the blade along the backbone** to the tail. The backbone sits high in a deep-bodied fish — aim higher than instinct suggests.
4. **Lift the ribs out** with a shallow arc.
5. **Skin from the tail.**
6. **Under 7 in, pan-dress instead:** scale against the grain with a knife back, gut, head off behind the gills, fins trimmed. Cook whole on the bone. More food and less work.

Bones and what to watch for

Spines	Sharp dorsal and anal spines. Shear them first.
Rib cage	Fine, easily removed.
No pin bones	Clean fillet.
Whole fish	The skeleton lifts out in one piece after cooking, which is the trick to show a child.

Cooking it

Method	How
Cornmeal-fried	Buttermilk, fine cornmeal, hot oil, two minutes a side. Exactly as bluegill. <i>see the Cooking Bluegill sheet</i>
Whole and crisp	Pan-dressed, scored, floured, shallow-fried until the fins crisp.
Mixed panfish fry	The normal outcome of a June evening: bluegill, pumpkinseed and a few crappie in one pan. No need to sort them.

Worth one lesson
Before you clean a June catch, sort the pile into bluegill and pumpkinseed by the ear flap — solid black versus an orange-red spot — and count each. It takes two minutes, it teaches an identification that sticks, and it tells you something real about which fish that bay is producing. <i>see the Pumpkinseed sheet</i>

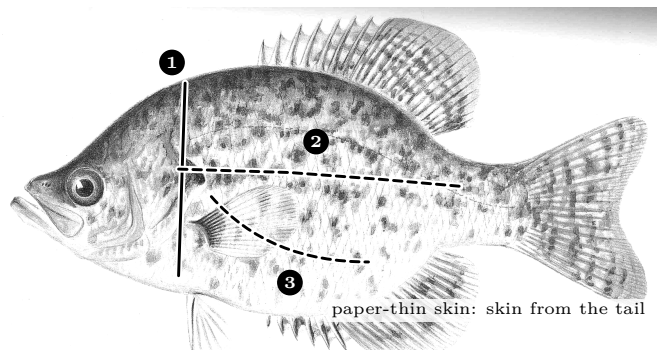
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Cooking Black Crappie

Pomoxis nigromaculatus — in the kitchen

The mildest fillet in the lake



Calico Bass; Strawberry Bass — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	The mildest and whitest of the panfish, with a slightly larger flake than bluegill. Many people rate it above every other panfish.
Texture	Soft, delicate, large-flaked for its size. Wants a gentle hand.
Best size	10 in and up. Crappie are thin fish, so a 10 in crappie yields less than a 10 in bass.
Yield	About 24%. Two fillets of roughly 2 oz from a 10 in fish.
Skin	Thin and tears easily. Skin from the tail with a firm grip.
Winter fish	Crappie taken through the ice are the best of the year — cold water firms the flesh noticeably.

Filleting

1. **Cut down behind the gill plate** and the pectoral fin, angling slightly toward the head, until the blade meets the backbone. Do not cut through it.
2. **Turn the blade flat** and run it along the top of the backbone to the tail in one long stroke, letting the spine guide the knife. Leave the fillet attached at the tail so it acts as a handle.
3. **Slice the rib cage out** in a shallow arc, taking as little flesh with it as you can.
4. **Skin it:** fillet skin-side down, grip the tail, run the knife between skin and flesh at a slight downward angle while pulling the skin against the blade.
5. Flip the fish and repeat. Rinse in cold water, pat dry, and get it onto ice.

Bones and what to watch for

The mouth	The membrane is famously thin, which is a fishing problem rather than a cleaning one — but it also means the head end tears easily under the knife. Cut, do not pull.
Rib cage	Fine and easily lifted.
No pin bones	Clean fillet once the ribs are out.
Handle gently	Crappie flesh is the softest here. Do not stack fillets under weight.

Cooking it

Method	How
Lightly fried	Seasoned flour only — a heavy batter buries a fish this mild. Butter, medium heat, two minutes a side.
Broiled with butter	Fillets on a buttered tray, paprika, lemon, six to eight minutes under a hot broiler. Nothing else needed.
Fish chowder	Crappie's softness is an asset in a chowder. Potato, onion, bacon, cream, and the fillets added in the last four minutes so they flake through.

Do not batter it heavily

Crappie is the mildest thing you will catch in these lakes, and the standard beer batter that suits walleye completely overwhelms it. Flour, butter and lemon. If you cannot taste the fish, the recipe is wrong for it.

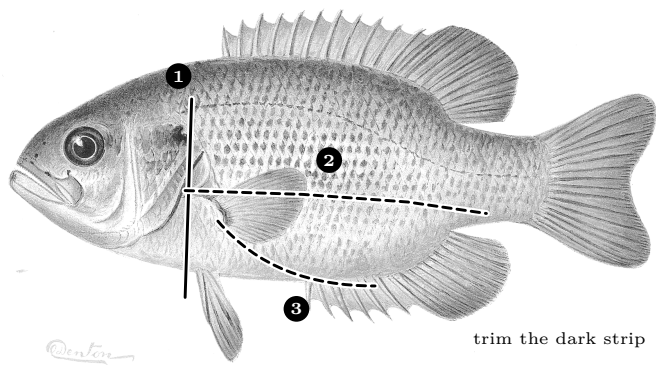
Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For bluegill, crappie, yellow perch, sunfish, rock bass and bullhead: **one serving per week** for women under 50 and children under 15; **unrestricted** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Cooking Black Crappie. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Cooking Rock Bass

Ambloplites rupestris — in the kitchen

Under-rated, abundant, and best eaten the day you catch it



Rock Bass — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Good — white, mild and perfectly pleasant, if a little softer than perch or bluegill. Badly under-rated because it is so easy to catch. ●●●●●
Texture	Softer and coarser than the other panfish. Best cooked hot and fast.
Freshness matters	This is the one panfish that noticeably deteriorates on a stringer. Ice it immediately and eat it the same day and it is genuinely good; leave it warm for three hours and it is not.
Best size	8 in and up. Pine Lake's gravel produces plenty.
Yield	About 22%. Deep-bodied, like a bluegill.
Counts as	Panfish, in the 25 per day aggregate.

Filleting

1. **Cut down behind the gill plate** and the pectoral fin, angling slightly toward the head, until the blade meets the backbone. Do not cut through it.
2. **Turn the blade flat** and run it along the top of the backbone to the tail in one long stroke, letting the spine guide the knife. Leave the fillet attached at the tail so it acts as a handle.
3. **Slice the rib cage out** in a shallow arc, taking as little flesh with it as you can.
4. **Skin it:** fillet skin-side down, grip the tail, run the knife between skin and flesh at a slight downward angle while pulling the skin against the blade.
5. Flip the fish and repeat. Rinse in cold water, pat dry, and get it onto ice.

Bones and what to watch for

Spines	Six anal spines — the identification mark — and a sharp spiny dorsal. Shear the dorsal off before you start.
Gill covers	Sharp-edged. Handle from the front.
Rib cage	Fine, lifts out easily.
Dark strip	Trim the lateral dark muscle as you would on a bass. It is where any muddiness sits.

Cooking it

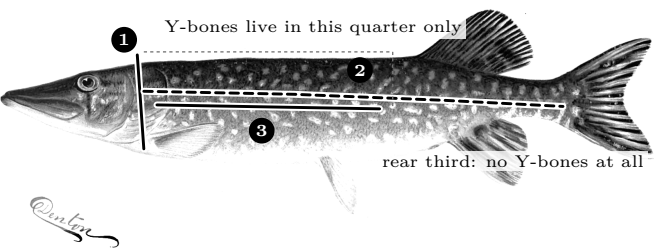
Method	How
Hot and fast	Cornmeal, very hot oil, ninety seconds a side. The softer flesh needs speed — a slow pan turns it to mush.
In a fish boil	Rock bass hold up in a pot better than they do in a pan. Potatoes, onions, salt, then the fish in for the last five minutes.
Cakes	Like bluegill, a good candidate for poaching, flaking and binding into patties when you have caught a lot of them.

The fish that saves the trip

Rock bass are aggressive, abundant, easy for a child to catch, and perfectly good on a plate the same evening. On a slow morning with a bored ten-year-old, a rock bass every three casts is worth more than a walleye you did not catch. *see the **A First Trip** sheet*

Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For bluegill, crappie, yellow perch, sunfish, rock bass and bullhead: **one serving per week** for women under 50 and children under 15; **unrestricted** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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The Pike — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	White, firm, clean and genuinely excellent — comparable to walleye. The Y-bones are the whole of its bad reputation and they are entirely solvable.
Texture	Firm and large-flaked, close to a cod. Holds together beautifully.
Best size	24–30 in. Big pike are coarser and are the breeders. The 26 in minimum here means you are keeping mid-size fish anyway.
Yield	About 30% by the five-fillet method — you deliberately sacrifice the Y-bone strip.
Slime	Pike are heavily slimed. Rinse in cold water before you start, and rinse the board between fish, or everything becomes slippery and dangerous.
Skin	Thick and strong. Comes off cleanly and is not eaten.

The five-fillet method — how to beat the Y-bones

A pike has an extra row of **Y-shaped intramuscular bones**, sitting above the lateral line in the *front half* of each fillet only. They are floating bones — they connect to nothing — so you cannot pull them like pin bones. You cut around them instead, and you deliberately give up a strip of meat. That is the whole trick, and it takes about two minutes once you have done it three times.

1. **Take two fillets normally.** Cut behind the gill plate to the backbone, turn the blade, run to the tail. Remove the ribs.
2. **Lay a fillet skin-side down.** Feel for the row of bone tips with a fingertip, running along the fillet slightly above the lateral line, from the head end back to roughly where the dorsal fin was — about the front 60% of the fillet. Behind that point there are none.
3. **Cut along the top of the Y-bones.** Starting at the head end, slice horizontally just *above* the bone tips, keeping the blade flat against them, until the cut runs out where the bones stop. This frees the whole upper-front section: **fillet one**, boneless.
4. **Cut along the bottom of the Y-bones.** Same again, this time just *below* the row, blade riding along the underside of the bones. This frees the lower-front section: **fillet two**, boneless.
5. **What is left** is a narrow strip containing every Y-bone, plus the rear third of the fillet which never had any. Cut the clean rear section off and keep it — **fillet three**.
6. Repeat on the other side. Five boneless pieces from one fish, and one bony strip that goes in the stockpot or the bin.

Bones and what to watch for

Y-bones	Above the lateral line, front 60% of the fillet only, floating and un-pullable. Cut above and below them, as in steps 3 and 4.
Do not try pliers	They break rather than pull, and you end up with bone fragments in the meat. This is the mistake everyone makes once.
The alternative	On smaller pike, score the fillet crossways every 3 mm down to the skin and deep-fry hot. The bones are fine enough to dissolve and become unnoticeable. It works, but the five-fillet method is better.
Pickling	Traditional and effective — the brine softens the Y-bones completely. Use a recipe with a boiling-water step, because the broad fish tapeworm is the one parasite in Wisconsin fish that matters to people.

Cooking it

Method	How
Beer-battered	Pike is firm enough to take a proper batter. 375 °F, three to four minutes. Many people who say they dislike pike have only ever eaten it badly cleaned.
Poached	The firm flake suits gentle cooking. Court-bouillon or milk with bay and peppercorns, eight minutes at a bare simmer. Cold with mayonnaise the next day is better still.
Pickled	Cube the flesh, brine in salt for 48 hours, rinse, then cover in a boiled and cooled vinegar-sugar-pickling-spice solution with sliced onion. Two weeks in the fridge. The classic Wisconsin treatment and it makes the Y-bone problem vanish entirely.

Do this once with somebody watching

The five-fillet method is very hard to learn from words and very easy to learn from one demonstration. Do the first pike slowly, with a finger on the bone row the whole time so you can feel where the blade is. After two fish it becomes automatic, and pike goes from a fish people throw back to one of the best on the lake. *see the **Northern Pike** sheet*

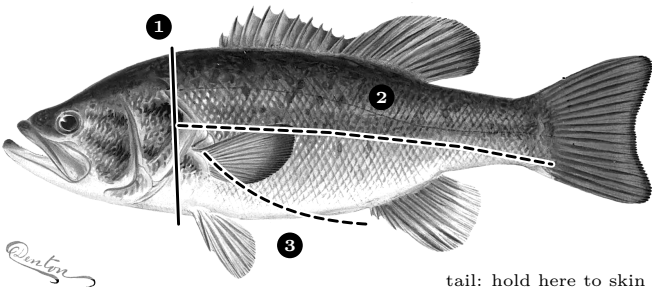
Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For walleye, pike, bass and catfish: **one serving per month** for women under 50 and children under 15; **one serving per week** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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Cooking Largemouth Bass

Better than its reputation, if you take it from cold water

Micropterus salmoides — in the kitchen



The Large-Mouthed Black Bass — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Much better than anglers say, provided the water was cold. A bass from 50 °F water in April is clean and sweet; the same fish in August can taste of weed and mud.
Texture	Firm and meaty, larger flake than walleye, holds up to grilling and to a heavier sauce.
The mud line	Flavour lives in the dark red lateral strip of muscle just under the skin. Trim it off and most of the complaint goes with it.
Best size	14–17 in. A big old bass is a breeder and coarse eating — put it back.
Yield	About 30% as skinless fillet. A 15 in bass gives two fillets of roughly 4 oz.
Season	Keep bass in spring and autumn; release them in high summer. This is a flavour judgement, not just a conservation one.

Filleting

1. **Cut down behind the gill plate** and the pectoral fin, angling slightly toward the head, until the blade meets the backbone. Do not cut through it.
2. **Turn the blade flat** and run it along the top of the backbone to the tail in one long stroke, letting the spine guide the knife. Leave the fillet attached at the tail so it acts as a handle.
3. **Slice the rib cage out** in a shallow arc, taking as little flesh with it as you can.
4. **Skin it:** fillet skin-side down, grip the tail, run the knife between skin and flesh at a slight downward angle while pulling the skin against the blade.
5. Flip the fish and repeat. Rinse in cold water, pat dry, and get it onto ice.

Bones and what to watch for

Rib cage	The only real bone structure. Step 3 removes it.
The red strip	Run the knife under the dark lateral muscle and lift it off. On a summer bass this is the difference between a good meal and a bad one.
Scales	If you are cooking skin-on, scale it first — largemouth scales are large, tough and will not soften.
Check by feel	Run a finger tip-to-tail before cooking.

Cooking it

Method	How
Blackened	Bass takes spice better than any other fish here. Coat heavily in paprika, cayenne, thyme, garlic and pepper. Very hot cast iron, butter, two to three minutes a side until the crust is dark. Cook it outside — it smokes.
Grilled in foil	Fillet, butter, lemon, onion, sealed in a foil packet. Twelve minutes over medium coals. Forgiving, and it keeps a firmer fish moist.
Fish tacos	Cube the fillet, dust with cumin and chilli, sear hard and fast. Warm tortillas, cabbage, lime, something creamy. Bass holds its shape in a taco where a bluegill would disintegrate.

Why bass has a bad name

Almost every complaint about eating bass comes from one of three things: a fish taken from warm summer water, the dark lateral strip left on, or a fish carried around on a stringer for hours before cleaning. Fix all three — cold water, trim the strip, ice it immediately — and it is a genuinely good fish. *see the **Handling & Release** sheet*

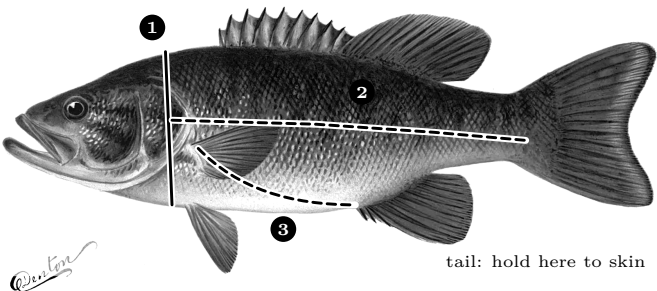
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Cooking Smallmouth Bass

Micropterus dolomieu — in the kitchen

Cleaner-tasting than its cousin, because of where it lives



The Small-Mouthed Black Bass — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Better eating than largemouth and noticeably cleaner, because smallmouth live over gravel and rock rather than in soft-bottomed weed. ●●●●●
Texture	Firm, white, tight-flaked. The best bass in either lake for the pan.
Flavour	Mild with a faint sweetness. A crayfish diet shows in the eating.
Best size	14–17 in. Pine Lake’s gravel bottom produces good ones.
Yield	About 32% as skinless fillet.
Worth saying	Smallmouth are the best sporting fish in these lakes and there are not many big ones. Take a meal, release the rest.

Filleting

1. **Cut down behind the gill plate** and the pectoral fin, angling slightly toward the head, until the blade meets the backbone. Do not cut through it.
2. **Turn the blade flat** and run it along the top of the backbone to the tail in one long stroke, letting the spine guide the knife. Leave the fillet attached at the tail so it acts as a handle.
3. **Slice the rib cage out** in a shallow arc, taking as little flesh with it as you can.
4. **Skin it:** fillet skin-side down, grip the tail, run the knife between skin and flesh at a slight downward angle while pulling the skin against the blade.
5. Flip the fish and repeat. Rinse in cold water, pat dry, and get it onto ice.

Bones and what to watch for

Rib cage	Removed at step 3. Nothing else to deal with.
Red strip	Less pronounced than on largemouth, but still worth trimming.
Skin	Comes away cleanly and is not worth eating.
Check by feel	Run a finger tip-to-tail before cooking.

Cooking it

Method	How
Pan-fried	Flour, salt, pepper, butter. Three minutes a side. Smallmouth is clean enough that heavy seasoning is a waste of it.
En papillote	Fillet on parchment with lemon, dill, a knob of butter and a splash of white wine. Fold and seal, 400 °F, twelve minutes. Opens at the table.
Over a fire	A whole gutted smallmouth, scored, stuffed with lemon and herbs, wrapped in foil and buried in coals for twenty minutes. The best thing you can do with one on the shore of the lake it came from.

Bottom matters

A fish tastes of where it lives. Smallmouth from Pine Lake’s clean gravel are consistently better than largemouth from the same lake’s soft weedy bays — same water, different bottom, different flavour. If you want to know how a lake will eat before you cook it, look at what is under the fish. *see the **Reading Water** sheet*

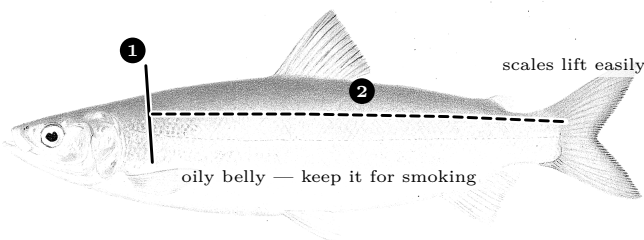
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Cooking Cisco

Coregonus artedii — in the kitchen

An oily, fine-fleshed fish that wants to be smoked



Cisco from Hemlock Lake — plate from the Freshwater and Marine Image Bank, University of Washington. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Excellent, but nothing like the others — rich, oily and fine-textured, closer to a small trout or a herring than to walleye. ●●●●○
Oil	High, and unusually so for these lakes. That is exactly why it smokes so well and why it does not keep long fresh.
Handling	The most perishable fish in the guide. Bleed it and ice it within minutes or the oil turns. This is not fussiness — a cisco left warm for two hours is not worth cooking.
Best size	10–14 in.
Yield	About 40%, the best in the guide — a straightforward, thick-bodied fish with a small head.
Season	Late autumn and through the ice, when they are at their fattest. <i>see the Cisco sheet</i>

Cleaning it

1. **Bleed it at the boat** — a cut through the gill arches — and put it straight on ice. This matters more for cisco than for anything else here.
2. **Scale it** if you are smoking or grilling skin-on. Cisco scales are large and lift with almost no effort.
3. **Gut it**, and for smoking leave the head on — it gives you something to hang it by.
4. **Or fillet normally:** behind the gill to the backbone, along the spine to the tail, ribs out. The flesh is soft, so use a sharp blade and few strokes.
5. **Leave the belly meat on.** It is the fattiest and best part, and it is what makes smoked cisco worth doing.

Bones and what to watch for

Pin bones	A row of fine pin bones runs down the fillet. Pull them with needle-nose pliers, in the direction they lean, before cooking.
Rib cage	Fine and soft.
Smoked whole	The frame lifts out in one piece after smoking — another reason to smoke rather than fillet.
Soft flesh	Handle gently and do not stack.

Cooking it

Method	How
Smoked	The right answer. Brine six hours in salt, brown sugar and water. Air-dry until tacky — that skin, the pellicle, is what smoke sticks to. Cold-smoke over apple or alder at 180 °F for three to four hours. Outstanding, and it keeps.
Grilled whole	Scaled, gutted, scored, oiled and salted. Hot grill, four minutes a side. The oil bastes it from inside.
Pan-fried	Fillets, skin on, skin-side down in a hot dry pan — there is enough fat in the fish that it needs almost no oil. Two minutes, flip, one minute.

The one fish here that rewards a smoker

Every other fish in this guide is lean, and lean fish smoke poorly — they go dry and stringy. Cisco is the exception, and a lake that holds them is unusual in this part of Wisconsin. If you have ever wanted a reason to build a smoker, a November cisco from Pine Lake is it. *see the **Cisco** sheet*

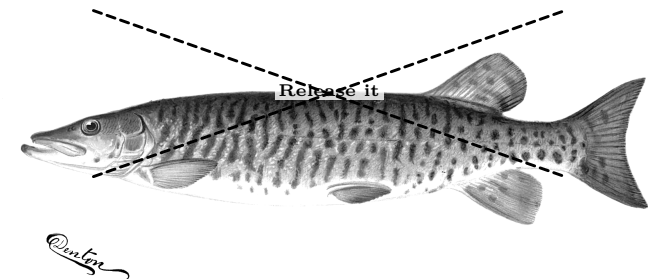
Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For all other species not listed as panfish: **one serving per month** for women under 50 and children under 15; **one serving per week** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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Cooking Muskellunge

Esox masquinongy — in the kitchen

Do not eat it — and here is the reason, in numbers



The Mascalonge — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Not a fish to eat, and this is the one sheet in the guide that says so. •••••
Mercury	Muskellunge sit at the top of the food chain and live for fifteen to twenty years, so they accumulate more mercury than anything else in the lake. Wisconsin's statewide guidance is do not eat for women under 50 and children under 15, and one serving per <i>month</i> for everybody else. No other species in this guide carries a do-not-eat line.
Scarcity	Musky are not among the species the DNR lists as common in either lake. A musky here is a rare, old, slow-growing fish.
Regulation	40 in minimum, one per day, open water only. A legal musky is a very large animal.
If you must	The flesh is white and firm, comparable to pike and with the same Y-bone structure. <i>see the Cooking Northern Pike sheet</i>
Better outcome	Photograph it in the net, measure it, and let it go.

If you catch one

1. **Confirm it is a musky and not a pike** before you do anything else. Dark marks on a light body, the lower half of both cheek and gill cover scaleless, six to nine pores per side of the lower jaw. *see the **Muskellunge** sheet*
2. **Measure it in the net, in the water.** Under 40 in it goes back regardless.
3. **Keep it horizontal and wet.** A large musky is injured by its own weight in air. Support the belly.
4. **Unhook it in the water** with long pliers and jaw spreaders. Cut the hook if it is awkward.
5. **Revive it properly** — upright, moving forward, until it swims off under its own power. A big musky may need several minutes.
6. **Photograph it low over the water**, so that if it kicks free it lands in the lake and not on the deck.

Bones and what to watch for

Same as pike	Y-bones above the lateral line in the front of each fillet, floating and un-pullable.
But	The bone structure is not the reason to leave it. The mercury load and the rarity of the fish are.
Handling	Teeth as bad as a pike's on a much larger animal. Jaw spreaders and long pliers, always.
Gear	A landing net big enough for the fish, ready before you hook one.

Cooking it

Method	How
—	This sheet does not carry recipes, and that is deliberate. If you want a large white-fleshed fish for the table from these waters, keep a legal northern pike instead: it eats as well, it is far more abundant, it grows faster, and it carries a fraction of the mercury.

Why this sheet exists

It would be easy to leave musky out of a cooking guide entirely. But somebody will eventually catch a legal one and want to know, and the honest answer is a number: Wisconsin's health guidance puts musky in a category by itself, alongside no other inland species. That is worth knowing before the fish is in the cooler rather than after.

Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For muskellunge: **do not eat** for women under 50 and children under 15; **one serving per month** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR's Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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